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JAMES SHIRLEY

The Lady of Pleasure

1635

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The best of Shirley’s comedies of manners, written for the Queen’s Men at the Cockpit. It is the comedy of the 1630s: witty, urban, and only a few years from the closing of the theatres.

The Project Gutenberg eBook of The chief Elizabethan dramatists, excluding Shakespeare

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE CHIEF ELIZABETHAN DRAMATISTS, EXCLUDING SHAKESPEARE ***
The edition's notes on this play's wording are gathered at the end of the text.

THE LADY OF PLEASURE

BY JAMES SHIRLEY

[DRAMATIS PERSONAE]

LORD - - .
SIR THOMAS BORNWELL.
SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE, }
MASTER ALEXANDER KICKSHAW, } [Gallants.]
MASTER JOHN LITTLEWORTH, }
MASTER HAIRCUT, [a Barber.]
MASTER FREDERICK, [nephew to Lady Bornwell.]
Steward to the Lady Aretina.
Steward to the Lady Celestina.
Secretary [to Lord - -].
Servants, etc.

ARETINA, Sir Thomas Bornwell's Lady.
CELESTINA, a young widow.
ISABELLA, }
MARIANA, } [Friends of Celestina.]
MADAM DECOY, [a Procuress.]
[Gentlewoman.]

SCENE. - The Strand.

ACT I

[SCENE I.][4233]

Enter Lady BORNWELL,[4234] and her Steward.

Stew. Be patient, madam; you may have your pleasure.

Lady B.[4234] 'T is that I came to town for. I would not
Endure again the country conversation,
To be the lady of six shires! The men,
So near the primitive making, they retain
A sense of nothing but the earth; their brains,
And barren heads standing as much in want
Of ploughing as their ground. To hear a fellow
Make himself merry and his horse, with whistling
Sellinger's Round![4235] To observe with what solemnity
They keep their wakes, and throw for pewter candle-sticks!
How they become the morris, with whose bells
They ring all in to Whitsun-ales; and sweat,
Through twenty scarfs and napkins, till the hobby-horse[4236]
Tire, and the Maid Marian,[4236] dissolv'd to a jelly,
Be kept for spoon meat!

Stew. These, with your pardon, are no argument
To make the country life appear so hateful;
At least to your particular, who enjoy'd
A blessing in that calm, would you be pleas'd
To think so, and the pleasure of a kingdom;
While your own will commanded what should move
Delights, your husband's love and power join'd
To give your life more harmony. You liv'd there
Secure, and innocent, belov'd of all;
Prais'd for your hospitality, and pray'd for:
You might be envi'd, but malice knew
Not where you dwelt. I would not prophesy,
But leave to your own apprehension,
What may succeed your change.

Lady B. You do imagine,
No doubt, you have talk'd wisely, and confuted

London past all defence. Your master should
Do well to send you back into the country,
With title of superintendent-bailiff.

Stew. How, madam!

Lady B. Even so, sir.

Stew. I am a gentleman,
Though now your servant.

Lady B. A country gentleman,
By your affection to converse with stubble.
His tenants will advance your wit, and plump it so
With beef and bag-pudding!

Stew. You may say your pleasure,
It becomes not me dispute.

Lady B. Complain to
The lord of the soil, your master.

Stew. You 're a woman
Of an ungovern'd passion, and I pity you.

Enter Sir THOMAS BORNWELL.

Born. How now? What 's the matter?

Stew. Nothing, sir. [Exit.]

Born. Angry, sweetheart?

Lady B. I am angry with myself,
To be so miserably restrain'd in things,
Wherein it doth concern your love and honour
To see me satisfied.

Born. In what, Aretina,
Dost thou accuse me? Have I not obey'd
All thy desires? Against mine own opinion
Quitted the country, and remov'd the hope
Of our return, by sale of that fair lordship
We liv'd in? Chang'd a calm and retir'd life
For this wild town, compos'd of noise and charge?[4237]

Lady B. What charge, more than is necessary for
A lady of my birth and education?

Born. I am not ignorant how much nobility
Flows in your blood; your kinsmen great and powerful
I' th' state; but with this, lose not you memory
Of being my wife. I shall be studious,
Madam, to give the dignity of your birth
All the best ornaments which become my fortune;
But would not flatter it, to ruin both,
And be the fable of the town, to teach
Other men loss of wit by mine, employ'd
To serve your vast expenses.

Lady B. Am I then
Brought in the balance? So, sir!

Born. Though you weigh
Me in a partial[4238] scale, my heart is honest,
And must take liberty to think you have
Obey'd no modest counsel, to affect,[4239]
Nay, study ways of pride and costly ceremony:
Your change of gaudy furniture, and pictures
Of this Italian master, and that Dutchman's;
Your mighty looking-glasses, like artillery,
Brought home on engines; the superfluous plate,
Antique and novel; vanities of tires;[4240]
Fourscore-pound suppers for my lord, your kinsman,
Banquets for t' other lady aunt, and cousins,
And perfumes that exceed all: train of servants,
To stifle us at home, and show abroad
More motley than the French or the Venetian,
About your coach, whose rude postillion
Must pester[4241] every narrow lane, till passengers
And tradesmen curse your choking up their stalls;
And common cries pursue your ladyship,
For hind'ring o' their market.

Lady B. Have you done, sir?

Born. I could accuse the gaiety of your wardrobe,
And prodigal embroideries, under which
Rich satins, plushes, cloth of silver, dare
Not show their own complexions; your jewels,
Able to burn out the spectators' eyes,
And show like bonfires on you by the tapers.
Something might here be spar'd, with safety of
Your birth and honour, since the truest wealth
Shines from the soul, and draws up just admirers. -
I could urge something more.

Lady B. Pray do, I like
Your homily of thrift.

Born. I could wish, madam,
You would not game so much.

Lady B. A gamester too!

Born. But are not come to that acquaintance yet,
Should teach you skill enough to raise your profit.
You look not through the subtilty of cards,
And mysteries of dice; nor can you save
Charge with the box, buy petticoats and pearls,
And keep your family by the precious income;
Nor do I wish you should: my poorest servant
Shall not upbraid my tables, nor his hire,
Purchas'd beneath my honour. You make play
Not a pastime but a tyranny, and vex
Yourself and my estate by it.

Lady B. Good! proceed.

Born. Another game you have, which consumes more
Your fame than purse; your revels in the night,
Your meetings called the "Ball," to which repair,
As to the Court of Pleasure, all your gallants
And ladies, thither bound by a subpoena
Of Venus, and small Cupid's high displeasure;
'T is but the Family of Love[4242] translated
Into more costly sin! There was a play on 't,[4243]
And had the poet not been brib'd to a modest
Expression of your antic gambols in 't,
Some darks had been discovered, and the deeds too.
In time he may repent, and make some blush,
To see the second part danc'd on the stage,
My thoughts acquit you for dishonouring me
By any foul act; but the virtuous know
'T is not enough to clear ourselves, but the
Suspicions of our shame.

Lady B. Have you concluded
Your lecture?

Born. I ha' done; and howsoever
My language may appear to you, it carries
No other than my fair and just intent
To your delights, without curb to their modest[4244]

And noble freedom.

Lady B. I 'll not be so tedious
In my reply; but, without art or elegance,
Assure you, I keep still my first opinion:
And though you veil your avaricious meaning
With handsome names of modesty and thrift,
I find you would intrench and wound the liberty
I was born with. Were my desires unprivileg'd
By example, while my judgment thought 'em fit,
You ought not to oppose; but when the practice
And track of every honourable lady
Authorise me, I take it great injustice
To have my pleasures circumscrib'd, and taught me.
A narrow-minded husband is a thief
To his own fame, and his preferment too;
He shuts his parts and fortunes from the world,
While, from the popular vote and knowledge, men
Rise to employment in the state.

Born. I have
No great ambition to buy preferment at
So dear a rate.

Lady B. Nor I to sell my honour,
By living poor and sparingly. I was not
Bred in that ebb of fortune, and my fate
Shall not compel me to it.

Born. I know not,
Madam; but you pursue these ways -

Lady B. What ways?

Born. In the strict sense of honesty, I dare
Make oath they are innocent.

Lady B. Do not divert,
By busy troubling of your brain, those thoughts
That should preserve 'em.

Born. How was that?

Lady B. 'T is English.

Born. But carries some unkind sense.

Enter MADAM DECOY.

Dec. Good morrow, my sweet madam.

Lady B. Decoy! welcome;
This visit is a favour.

Dec. Alas, sweet madam,
I cannot stay: I came but to present
My service to your ladyship; I could not
Pass by your door, but I must take the boldness
To tender my respects.

Lady B. You oblige me, madam;
But I must not dispense so with your absence.

Dec. Alas, the coach, madam, stays for me at the door.

Lady B. Thou sha't command mine; prithee, sweet Decoy -

Dec. I would wait on you, madam, but I have many
Visits to make this morning; I beseech -

Lady B. So you will promise to dine with me.

Dec. I shall
Present a guest.

Lady B. Why, then good morrow, madam.

Dec. A happy day shine on your ladyship! Exit.

Re-enter Steward.

Lady B. What's your news, sir?

Stew. Madam, two gentlemen.

Lady B. What gentlemen? Have they no names?

Stew. They are
The gentleman with his own head of hair,
Whom you commended for his horsemanship
In Hyde Park, and becoming so the saddle,
The t' other day.

Lady B. What circumstance is this
To know him by?

Stew. His name 's at my tongue's end: -
He lik'd the fashion of your pearl chain, madam;
And borrowed it for his jeweller to take
A copy by it.

Born. [Aside.] What cheating gallant 's this?

Stew. That never walks without a lady's busk,[4245]
And plays with fans - Master Alexander Kickshaw, -
I thought I should remember him.

Lady B. What 's the other?

Stew. What an unlucky memory I have!
The gallant that still danceth in the street,
And wears a gross of ribbon in his hat;
That carries oringado[4246] in his pocket,
And sugar-plums, to sweeten his discourse;
That studies compliment, defies all wit
In black, and censures plays that are not bawdy -
Master John Littleworth.

Lady B. They are welcome; but
Pray entertain them a small time, lest I
Be unprovided.

Born. Did they ask for me?

Stew. No, sir.

Born. It matters not, they must be welcome.

Lady B. Fie! how 's this hair disordered? Here 's a curl
Straddles most impiously. I must to my closet. Exit.

Born. Wait on 'em; my lady will return again. [Exit Steward.]
I have to such a height fulfill'd[4247] her humour,
All application 's[4248] dangerous: these gallants
Must be receiv'd, or she will fall into
A tempest, and the house be shook with names
Of all her kindred. 'T is a servitude
I may in time shake off.

Enter ALEXANDER [KICKSHAW] and LITTLEWORTH.

Kick. and Little. Save you, Sir Thomas!

Born. Save you, gentlemen!

Kick. I kiss your hand.

Born. What[4249] day is it abroad?

Little. The morning rises from your lady's eye:
If she look clear, we take the happy omen
Of a fair day.

Born. She 'll instantly appear,
To the discredit of your compliment;
But you express your wit thus.

Kick. And you modesty,
Not to affect[4250] the praises of your own.

Born. Leaving this subject, what game 's now on foot?
What exercise carries the general vote
O' the town? Nothing moves without your knowledge.

Kick. The cocking now has all the noise; I 'll have
A hundred pieces of one battle. - Oh,
These birds of Mars!

Little. Venus is Mars his bird too.

Kick. Why, and the pretty doves are Venus's,
To show that kisses draw the chariot.

Little. I am for that skirmish.

Born. When shall we have
More booths and bagpipes upon Banstead downs?
No mighty race is expected? - But my lady
Returns!

Re-enter LADY BORNWELL.

Lady B. Fair morning to you, gentlemen!
You went not late to bed by your early visit.
You do me honour.

Kick. It becomes our service.

Lady B. What news abroad? You hold precious intelligence.

Little. All tongues are so much busy with your praise,
They have not time to frame other discourse.

Will 't please you, madam, taste a sugar-plum?

Born. What does the goldsmith think the pearl is worth
You borrowed of my lady?

Kick. 'T is a rich one.

Born. She has many other toys, whose fashion you
Will like extremely: you have no intention
To buy any of her jewels?

Kick. Understand me -

Born. You had rather sell, perhaps. But, leaving this,
I hope you 'll dine with us.

Kick. I came a' purpose.

Lady B. And where were you last night?

Kick. I, madam? Where
I slept not; it had been sin, where so much
Delight and beauty was to keep me waking.
There is a lady, madam, will be worth
Your free society; my conversation
Ne'er knew so elegant and brave a soul,
With most incomparable flesh and blood;
So spirited! so courtly! speaks the languages,
Sings, dances, plays o' th' lute to admiration!
Is fair, and paints not; games too, keeps a table,
And talks most witty satire; has a wit
Of a clean Mercury -

Little. Is she married?

Kick. No.

Lady B. A virgin?

Kick. Neither.

Little. What! a widow! Something
Of this wide commendation might have
Excus'd. This such a prodigy!

Kick. Repent,
Before I name her: she did never see
Yet full sixteen, an age, in the opinion

Of wise men, not contemptible. She has
Mourn'd out her year, too, for the honest knight
That had compassion of her youth, and died
So timely. Such a widow is not common;
And now she shines more fresh and tempting
Than any natural virgin.

Lady B. What 's her name?

Kick. She was christened Celestina; by her husband,
The Lady Bellamour: this ring was hers.

Born. You borrowed it to copy out the posy.

Kick. Are they not pretty rubies? 't was a grace
She was pleas'd to show me, that I might have one
Made of the self-same fashion; for I love
All pretty forms.

Lady B. And is she glorious?

Kick. She is full of jewels, madam; but I am
Most taken with the bravery of her mind,
Although her garments have all grace and ornament.

Lady B. You have been high in praises.

Kick. I come short;
No flattery can reach her.

Born. [Aside.] Now my lady
Is troubled, as she fear'd to be eclips'd:
This news will cost me somewhat.

Lady B. You deserve
Her favour, for this noble character.

Kick. And I possess it, by my stars benevolence.

Lady B. You must bring us acquainted.

Born. I pray do, sir;
I long to see her too. - Madam, I have
Thought upon 't, and corrected my opinion.
Pursue what ways of pleasure your desires
Incline you to, not only with my state,
But with my person; I will follow you.
I see the folly of my thrift, and will

Repent in sack and prodigality,
To your own heart's content.

Lady B. But do not mock.

Born. Take me to your embraces, gentlemen,
And tutor me.

Little. And will you kiss the ladies?

Born. And sing and dance. I long to see this beauty;
I would fain lose a hundred pounds at dice now.
Thou sha't have another gown and petticoat
To-morrow. Will you sell my running-horses?
We have no Greek wine in the house, I think;
Pray send one of our footmen to the merchant,
And throw the hogshead of March-beer into
The kennel,[4251] to make room for sack and claret.
What think you to be drunk yet before dinner?
We will have constant music, and maintain
Them and their fiddles in fantastic liveries:
I 'll tune my voice to catches. I must have
My dining-room enlarg'd, to invite ambassadors.
We 'll feast the parish in the fields, and teach
The military men new discipline,
Who shall charge all their great artillery
With oranges and lemons, boy, to play
All dinner upon our capons.

Kick. He 's exalted!

Born. I will do anything to please my lady,
Let that suffice; and kiss o' th' same condition.
I am converted; do not you dispute,
But patiently allow the miracle.

Lady B. I am glad to hear you, sir, in so good tune.

Enter Servant.

Serv. Madam, the painter.

Lady B. I am to sit this morning.

Born. Do, while I give new directions to my steward.

Kick. With your favour, we'll wait on you: sitting's but
A melancholy exercise without

Some company to discourse.

Lady B. It does conclude
A lady's morning work. We rise, make fine,
Sit for our picture, and 't is time to dine.

Little. Praying's forgot.

Kick. 'T is out of fashion. Exeunt.

[SCENE II.][4252]

Enter CELESTINA and her Steward.

Cel. Fie! what an air this room has!

Stew. 'T is perfum'd.

Cel. With some cheap stuff. Is it your wisdom's thrift
To infect my nostrils thus? Or is't to favour
The gout in your worship's hand, you are afraid
To exercise your pen in your account book?
Or do you doubt my credit to discharge
Your bills?

Stew. Madam, I hope you have not found
My duty, with the guilt of sloth or jealousy,
Unapt to your command.

Cel. You can extenuate
Your faults with language, sir; but I expect
To be obey'd. What hangings have we here!

Stew. They are arras, madam.

Cel. Impudence! I know't.
I will have fresher, and more rich; not wrought
With faces that may scandalize a Christian,
With Jewish stories stuft with corn and camels.
You had best wrap all my chambers in wild Irish,
And make a nursery of monsters here,
To fright the ladies come to visit me.

Stew. Madam, I hope -

Cel. I say I will have other,
Good Master Steward, of a finer loom;

Some silk and silver, if your worship please
To let me be at so much cost. I'll have
Stories to fit the seasons of the year,
And change as often as I please.

Stew. You shall, madam.

Cel. I am bound to your consent, forsooth! And is
My coach brought home?

Stew. This morning I expect it.

Cel. The inside, as I gave direction,
Of crimson plush?

Stew. Of crimson camel plush.

Cel. Ten thousand moths consume 't! Shall I ride through
The streets in penance, wrapt up round in hair cloth?
Sell't to an alderman, 't will serve his wife
To go a feasting to their country-house;
Or fetch a merchant's nurse-child, and come home
Laden with fruit and cheese-cakes. I despise it!

Stew. The nails adorn it, madam, set in method,
And pretty forms.

Cel. But single gilt, I warrant.

Stew. No, madam.

Cel. Another solecism! Oh fie!
This fellow will bring me to a consumption
With fretting at his ignorance. Some lady
Had rather never pray than go to church in't.
The nails not double gilt! To market wo't?[4253]
'T will hackney out to Mile-end, or convey
Your city tumblers[4254] to be drunk with cream
And prunes at Islington.[4255]

Stew. Good madam, hear me.

Cel. I'll rather be beholding to my aunt,
The countess, for her mourning coach, than be
Disparag'd so. Shall any juggling tradesman
Be at charge to shoe his running-horse with gold,
And shall my coach nails be but single gilt!
How dare these knaves abuse me so?

Stew. Vouchsafe
To hear me speak.

Cel. Is my sedan yet finish'd,
And liveries for my men-mules,[4256] according
As I gave charge?

Stew. Yes, madam, it is finish'd,
But without tilting-plumes at the four corners;
The scarlet's pure, but not embroidered.

Cel. What mischief were it to your conscience
Were my coach lin'd with tissue, and my harness
Cover'd with needle-work? if my sedan
Had all the story of the prodigal
Embroidered with pearl?

Stew. Alas, good madam,
I know 't is your own cost; I am but your steward,
And would discharge my duty the best way,
You have been pleas'd to hear me; 't is not for
My profit that I manage your estate
And save expense, but for your honour, madam.

Cel. How, sir! my honour?

Stew. Though you hear it not,
Men's tongues are liberal in your character,
Since you began to live thus high. I know
Your fame is precious to you.

Cel. I were best
Make you my governor. Audacious varlet!
How dare you interpose your doting counsel?
Mind your affairs with more obedience,
Or I shall ease you of an office, sir.
Must I be limited to please your honour,
Or, for the vulgar breath, confine my pleasures?
I will pursue 'em in what shapes I fancy,
Here, and abroad; my entertainments shall
Be oft'ner, and more rich. Who shall control me?
I live i' th' Strand, whither few ladies come
To live, and purchase more than fame. I will
Be hospitable then, and spare no cost
That may engage all generous report
To trumpet forth my bounty and my bravery,[4257]
Till the court envy, and remove. I'll have

My house the academy of wits, who shall
Exalt their genius with rich sack and sturgeon,
Write panegyrics of my feasts, and praise
The method of my witty superfluities.
The horses shall be taught, with frequent waiting
Upon my gates, to stop in their career
Toward Charing-cross, spite of the coachman's fury;
And not a tilter but shall strike[4258] his plume,
When he sails by my window: my balcony
Shall be the courtier's idol, and more gaz'd at
Than all the pageantry at Temple Bar,
By country clients.

Stew. Sure my lady's mad.

Cel. Take that for your ill manners. [Strikes him.]

Stew. Thank you, madam. -
I would there were less quicksilver in your fingers. Exit.

Cel. There 's more than simple honesty in a servant
Requir'd to his full duty; none should dare
But with a look, much less a saucy language,
Check at their mistress' pleasure. I'm resolv'd
To pay for some delight, my estate will bear it;
I'll rein it shorter when I please.

Re-enter Steward.

Stew. A gentleman
Desires to speak with your ladyship.

Cel. His name?

Stew. He says you know him not; he seems to be
Of quality.

Cel. Admit him. [Exit Steward.]
Enter HAIRCUT.
Sir, with me?

Hair. Madam, I know not how you may receive
This boldness from me; but my fair intents
Known, will incline you to be charitable.

Cel. No doubt, sir.

Hair. He must live obscurely, madam,

That hath not heard what virtues you possess;
And I, a poor admirer of your fame,
Am come to kiss your hand.

Cel. That all your business?

Hair. Though it were worth much travel, I have more
In my ambition.

Cel. Speak it freely, sir.

Hair. You are a widow.

Cel. So!

Hair. And I a bachelor.

Cel. You come a wooing, sir, and would perhaps
Show me a way to reconcile the two?

Hair. And bless my stars for such a happiness.

Cel. I like you, sir, the better, that you do not
Wander about, but shoot home to the meaning;
It is a confidence will make a man
Know sooner what to trust to: but I never
Saw you before, and I believe you come not
With hope to find me desperate upon marriage.
If maids, out of their ignorance of what
Men are, refuse these offers, widows may,
Out of their knowledge, be allow'd some coyness:
And yet I know not how much happiness
A peremptory answer may deprive me of; -
You may be some young lord, and though I see not
Your footmen and your groom, they may not be
Far off, in conference with your horse. Please you
To instruct me with your title, against which
I would not willingly offend.

Hair. I am
A gentleman; my name is Haircut, madam.

Cel. Sweet Master Haircut, are you a courtier?

Hair. Yes.

Cel. I did think so, by your confidence.
Not to detain you, sir, with circumstance,

I was not so unhappy in my husband,
But that 't is possible I may be a wife
Again; but I must tell you, he that wins
My affection, shall deserve me.

Hair. I will hope,
If you can love, I shall not present, madam,
An object to displease you in my person:
And when time, and your patience, shall possess you
With further knowledge of me, and the truth
Of my devotion, you will not repent
The offer of my service.

Cel. You say well.
How long do you imagine you can love, sir?
Is it a quotidian, or will it hold
But every other day?

Hair. You are pleasant,[4259] madam.

Cel. Does it take you with a burning at the first,
Or with a cold fit? for you gentlemen
Have both your summer and your winter service.

Hair. I am ignorant what you mean; but I shall never
Be cold in my affection to such beauty.

Cel. And 't will be somewhat long ere I be warm in't.

Hair. If you vouchsafe me so much honour, madam,
That I may wait on you sometimes, I sha' not
Despair to see a change.

Cel. But now I know
Your mind, you shall not need to tell it when
You come again; I shall remember it.

Hair. You make me fortunate.

Re-enter Steward.

Stew. Madam, your kinswomen,
The lady Novice, and her sister, are
New lighted from their coach.

Cel. I did expect 'em,
They partly are my pupils. I 'll attend 'em. [Exit Steward.]

Hair. Madam, I have been too great a trespasser
Upon your patience; I will take my leave.
You have affairs, and I have some employment
Calls me to court; I shall present again
A servant to you. Exit.

Cel. Sir, you may present,
But not give fire, I hope. - Now to the ladies.
This recreation 's past, the next must be
To read to them some court philosophy. Exit.

ACT II

SCENE I.[4260]

Enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL.

Born. 'T is a strange humour I have undertaken,
To dance, and play, and spend as fast as she does;
But I am resolv'd: it may do good upon her,
And fright her into thrift. Nay, I 'll endeavour
To make her jealous too; if this do not
Allay her gamboling, she 's past a woman,
And only a miracle must tame her.

Enter Steward.

Stew. 'T is master Frederick, my lady's nephew.

Born. What of him?

Stew. Is come from the university.

Born. By whose directions?

Stew. It seems, my lady's.

Born. Let me speak with him
Before he see his aunt. [Exit Stew.] - I do not like it. -
Enter [Steward, with] MASTER FREDERICK, [in his college dress.]
Master Frederick, welcome! I expected not
So soon your presence; what 's the hasty cause?

Fred. These letters, from my tutor, will acquaint you.

[Gives BORNWELL letters.]

Stew. Welcome home, sweet Master Frederick!

Fred. Where 's my aunt?

Stew. She 's busy about her painting, in her closet;
The outlandish man of art is copying out
Her countenance.

Fred. She is sitting for her picture?

Stew. Yes, sir; and when 't is drawn she will be hang'd
Next the French cardinal, in the dining-room.
But when she hears you 're come, she will dismiss
The Belgic gentleman, to entertain
Your worship.

Fred. Change of air has made you witty.

Born. Your tutor gives you a handsome character,
Frederick, and is sorry your aunt's pleasure
Commands you from your studies; but I hope
You have no quarrel to the liberal arts.
Learning is an addition[4261] beyond
Nobility of birth. Honour of blood,
Without the ornament of knowledge, is
A glorious[4262] ignorance.

Fred. I never knew more sweet and happy hours
Than I employ'd upon my books. I heard
A part of my philosophy, and was so
Delighted with the harmony of nature,
I could have wasted my whole life upon 't.

Born. [Aside.] 'T is pity a rash indulgence should corrupt
So fair a genius! She 's here; I 'll observe.

Enter Lady BORNWELL, KICKSHAW, and LITTLEWORTH.

Fred. My most lov'd aunt!

Lady B. Support me, I shall faint.

Little. What ails your ladyship?

Lady B. Is that Frederick,
In black?

Kick. Yes, madam; but the doublet 's satin.

Lady B. The boy 's undone!

Fred. Madam, you appear troubled.

Lady B. Have I not cause? Was not I trusted with
Thy education, boy, and have they sent thee
Home like a very scholar!

Kick. 'T was ill done,
Howe'er they us'd him in the university,
To send him to his friends thus.

Fred. Why, sir? Black,
(For 't is the colour that offends your eye-sight,)
Is not, within my reading, any blemish;
Sables are no disgrace in heraldry.

Kick. 'T is coming from the college thus, that makes it
Dishonourable. While you wore it for
Your father, it was commendable; or were
Your aunt dead, you might mourn, and justify.

Lady B. What luck[4263] I did not send him into France!
They would have given him generous education,
Taught him another garb, to wear his lock,[4264]
And shape, as gaudy as the summer; how
To dance, and wag his feather à-la-mode,
To compliment, and cringe; to talk not modestly,
Like, "ay forsooth," and "no forsooth;" to blush,
And look so like a chaplain! - There he might
Have learn'd a brazen confidence, and observ'd
So well the custom of the country, that
He might, by this time, have invented fashions
For us, and been a benefit to the kingdom;
Preserv'd our tailors in their wits, and sav'd
The charge of sending into foreign courts
For pride and antic fashions. - Observe
In what a posture he does hold his hat now!

Fred. Madam, with your pardon, you have practis'd
Another dialect than was taught me when
I was commended to your care and breeding.
I understand not this; Latin or Greek
Are more familiar to my apprehension:
Logic was not so hard in my first lectures

As your strange language.

Lady B. Some strong waters; oh!

Little. Comfits will be as comfortable to your stomach, madam.
[Offers his box.]

Lady B. I fear he 's spoil'd for ever! He did name
Logic, and may, for aught I know, be gone
So far to understand it. I did always
Suspect they would corrupt him in the college. -
Will your Greek saws and sentences discharge
The mercer? Or is Latin a fit language
To court a mistress in? - Master Alexander,
If you have any charity, let me
Commend him to your breeding. - I suspect
I must employ my doctor first, to purge
The university that lies in 's head;
It alters his complexion.

Kick. If you dare
Trust me to serve him -

Lady B. Master Littleworth,
Be you join'd in commission.

Little. I will teach him
Postures and rudiments.

Lady B. I have no patience
To see him in this shape; it turns my stomach.
When he has cast his academic skin
He shall be yours. I am bound in conscience
To see him bred; his own state shall maintain
The charge, while he 's my ward. - Come hither, sir.

Fred. What does my aunt mean to do with me?

Stew. To make you a fine gentleman, and translate you
Out of your learned language, sir, into
The present Goth and Vandal, which is French.

Born. [Aside.] Into what mischief will this humour ebb?
She will undo the boy; I see him ruin'd.
My patience is not manly; but I must
Use stratagem to reduce her: open ways
Give me no hope.

Stew. You shall be obey'd, madam.
Exeunt [all but FREDERICK and Steward].

Fred. Master Steward, are you sure we do not dream?
Was 't not my aunt you talkt to?

Stew. One that loves you
Dear as her life. These clothes do not become you,
You must have better, sir -

Fred. There are not old.

Stew. More suitable to the town and time; we keep
No Lent here, nor is 't my lady's pleasure you
Should fast from anything you have a mind to;
Unless it be your learning, which she would have you
Forget with all convenient speed that may be,
For the credit of your noble family.
The case is alter'd since we liv'd i' th' country;
We do not now invite the poor o' th' parish
To dinner, keep a table for the tenants;
Our kitchen does not smell of beef; the cellar
Defies the price of malt and hops; the footmen
And coach-drivers may be drunk like gentlemen,
With wine; nor will three fiddlers upon holidays,
With aid of bag-pipes, that call'd in the country
To dance, and plough the hall up with their hob-nails,
Now make my lady merry. We do feed
Like princes, and feast nothing else but princes;
And are these robes fit to to be seen amongst 'em?

Fred. My lady keeps a court then! Is Sir Thomas
Affected[4265] with this state and cost?

Stew. He was not,
But is converted: and I hope you wo' not
Persist in heresy, but take a course
Of riot, to content your friends; you shall
Want nothing, if you can be proud, and spend it
For my lady's honour. Here are a hundred
Pieces, will serve you till you have new clothes;
I will present you with a nag of mine,
Poor tender of my service, please you accept;
My lady's smile more than rewards me for it.
I must provide fit servants to attend you,
Monsieurs, for horse and foot.

Fred. I shall submit,

If this be my aunt's pleasure, and be rul'd;
My eyes are open'd with this purse already,
And sack will help to inspire me. I must spend it?

Stew. What else, sir?

Fred. I 'll begin with you: to encourage
You to have still a special care of me,
There is five pieces, - not for your nag.

Stew. No, sir; I hope it is not.

Fred. Buy a beaver
For thy own block;[4266] I shall be rul'd. Who does
Command the wine cellar?

Stew. Who commands but you, sir?

Fred. I 'll try to drink a health or two, my aunt's,
Or anybody's; and if that foundation
Stagger me not too much, I will commence
In all the arts of London.

Stew. If you find, sir,
The operation of the wine exalt
Your blood to the desire of any female
Delight, I know your aunt wo' not deny
Any of her chambermaids to practise on;
She loves you but too well.

Fred. I know not how
I may be for that exercise. - Farewell, Aristotle,
Prithee commend me to the library
At Westminster; my bones I bequeath thither,
And to the learned worms that mean to visit 'em.
I will compose myself; I begin to think
I have lost time indeed. - Come to the wine cellar. Exeunt.

[SCENE II.][4267]

Enter CELESTINA, MARIANA, and ISABELLA.

Mar. But shall we not, madam, expose ourselves
To censure for this freedom?

Cel. Let them answer
That dare mistake us. Shall we be so much

Cowards, to be frighted from our pleasure,
Because men have malicious tongues, and show
What miserable souls they have? No, cousin,
We hold our life and fortunes upon no
Man's charity; if they dare show so little
Discretion to traduce our fames, we will
Be guilty of so much wit to laugh at 'em.

Isab. 'T is a becoming fortitude.

Cel. My stars
Are yet kind to me; for, in a happy minute
Be 't spoke, I 'm not in love, and men shall never
Make my heart lean with sighing, nor with tears
Draw on my eyes the infamy of spectacles.
'T is the chief principle to keep your heart
Under your own obedience; jest, but love not.
I say my prayers, yet can wear good clothes,
And only satisfy my tailor for 'em.
I will not lose my privilege.

Mar. And yet they say your entertainments are,
Give me your pardon, madam, to proclaim
Yourself a widow, and to get a husband.

Cel. As if a lady of my years, some beauty,
Left by her husband rich, that had mourn'd for him
A twelvemonth too, could live so obscure i' th' town,
That gallants would not know her, and invite
Themselves, without her chargeable[4268] proclamations!
Then we are worse than citizens: no widow
Left wealthy can be thoroughly warm in mourning,
But some one noble blood, or lusty kindred,
Claps in, with his gilt coach, and Flandrian[4269] trotters,
And hurries her away to be a countess.
Courtiers have spies, and great ones with large titles,
Cold in their own estates, would warm themselves
At a rich city bonfire.

Isab. Most true, madam.

Cel. No matter for corruption of the blood:
Some undone courtier made her husband rich,
And this new lord receives it back again.
Admit it were my policy, and that
My entertainments pointed to acquaint me
With many suitors, that I might be safe
And make the best election, could you blame me?

Mar. Madam, 't is wisdom.

Cel. But I should be
In my thoughts miserable, to be fond[4270]
Of leaving the sweet freedom I possess,
And court myself into new marriage fetters.
I now observe men's several wits and windings,[4271]
And can laugh at their follies.

Mar. You have given
A most ingenious satisfaction.

Cel. One thing I 'll tell you more, and this I give you
Worthy your imitation, from my practice:
You see me merry, full of song and dancing,
Pleasant in language, apt to all delights
That crown a public meeting; but you cannot
Accuse me of being prodigal of my favours
To any of my guests. I do not summon,
By any wink, a gentleman to follow me
To my withdrawing chamber; I hear all
Their pleas in court, nor can they boast abroad,
And do me justice, after a salute,[4272]
They have much conversation with my lip.
I hold the kissing of my hand a courtesy,
And he that loves me, must, upon the strength
Of that, expect till I renew his favour.
Some ladies are so expensive in their graces
To those that honour 'em, and so prodigal,
That in a little time they have nothing but
The naked sin left to reward their servants;
Whereas, a thrift in our rewards will keep
Men long in their devotion, and preserve
Ourselves in stock, to encourage those that honour us.

Isab. This is an art worthy a lady's practice.

Cel. It takes not from the freedom of our mirth,
But seems to advance it, when we can possess
Our pleasures with security of our honour;
And, that preserv'd, I welcome all the joys
My fancy can let in. In this I have given
The copy of my mind; nor do I blush
You understand it.

Isab. You have honour'd us.

Enter CELESTINA'S Gentlewoman.

Gentlew. Madam, Sir William Scentlove's come to wait on you.

Cel. There 's one would be a client. - Make excuse
For a few minutes. [Exit Gentlewoman.]

Mar. One that comes a wooing?

Cel. Such a thing he would seem, but in his guiltiness
Of little land, his expectation is not
So valiant as it might be. He wears rich clothes,
And feeds with noblemen; to some, I hear,
No better than a wanton emissary,
Or scout for Venus' wild fowl; which made tame,
He thinks no shame to stand court sentinel,
In hope of the reversion.

Mar. I have heard
That some of them are often my lord's tasters,
The first fruits they condition for, and will
Exact as fees, for the promotion.

Cel. Let them agree; there 's no account shall lie
For me among their traffic.

Re-enter Gentlewoman.

Gentlew. Master Haircut, madam,
Is new come in, to tender you his service.

Cel. Let him discourse a little with Sir William.
Exit Gentlewoman.

Mar. What is this gentleman, Master Haircut, madam?
I note him very gallant, and much courted
By gentlemen of quality.

Cel. I know not,
More than a trim gay man; he has some great office,
Sure, by his confident behaviour.
He would be entertain'd under the title
Of servant[4273] to me, and I must confess,
He is the sweetest of all men that visit me.

Isab. How mean you, madam?

Cel. He is full of powder;

He will save much in perfume for my chamber,
Were he but constant here. - Give 'em access.

Enter SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE and HAIRCUT.

Scent. Madam, the humblest of your servants is
Exalted to a happiness, if you smile
Upon my visit.

Hair. I must beg your charity
Upon my rudeness, madam; I shall give
That day up lost to any happiness,
When I forget to tender you my service.

Cel. You practise courtship, gentlemen.

Scent. But cannot
Find where with more desert to exercise it.
What lady 's this, I pray?

Cel. A kinswoman
Of mine, Sir William.

Scent. I am more her servant.

Cel. You came from court, now, I presume?

Hair. 'T is, madam,
The sphere I move in, and my destiny
Was kind to place me there, where I enjoy
All blessings that a mortal can possess,
That lives not in your presence; and I should
Fix my ambition, when you would vouchsafe
Me so much honour, to accept from me
An humble entertainment there.

Cel. But by
What name shall I be known? In what degree
Shall I be of kindred to you?

Hair. How mean you, madam?

Cel. Perhaps you 'll call me sister, I shall take it
A special preferment; or it may be
I may pass under title of your mistress,
If I seem rich, and fair enough, to engage
Your confidence to own me.

Hair. I would hope -

Cel. But 't is not come to that yet: you will, sir.
Excuse my mirth.

Hair. Sweet madam!

Cel. Shall I take
Boldness to ask what place you hold in court?
'T is an uncivil curiosity;
But you 'll have mercy to a woman's question.

Hair. My present condition, madam, carries
Honour and profit, though not to be nam'd
With that employment I expect i' th' state,
Which shall discharge the first maturity
Upon your knowledge; until then, I beg
You allow a modest silence.

Cel. I am charm'd, sir;
And if you scape ambassador, you cannot
Reach a preferment wherein I 'm against you.
But where is Sir William Scentlove?

Hair. Give him leave
To follow his nose, madam, while he hunts
In view, - he 'll soon be at a fault.[4274]

Cel. You know him?

Hair. Know Scentlove? Not a page but can decipher him;
The waiting-women know him to a scruple;
He 's called the blister-maker of the town.

Cel. What 's that?

Hair. The laundry ladies can resolve you,
And you may guess: an arrant epicure,
As this day lives, born to a pretty wit,
A knight, too; but no gentleman. I must
Be plain to you; - your ladyship may have
Use of this knowledge, but conceal the author.

Scent. I kiss your fairest hand.

Mar. You make a difference;
Pray reconcile them to an equal whiteness.

Scent. You wound my meaning, lady.

Cel. Nay, Sir William
Has the art of compliment.

Scent. Madam, you honour me
'Bove my desert of language.

Cel. Will you please
To enrich me with your knowledge of that gentleman?

Scent. Do you not know him, madam?

Cel. What is he?

Scent. A camphire ball; you shall know more hereafter;
He shall tell you himself, and save my character;
Till then, - you see he 's proud.

Cel. One thing, gentlemen,
I observe in your behaviour, which is rare
In two that court one mistress: you preserve
A noble friendship; there 's no gum within
Your hearts; you cannot fret,[4275] or show an envy
Of one another's hope; some would not govern
Their passions with that temper!

Scent. The whole world
Shall nor divorce our friendship. - Master Haircut!
Would I had lives to serve him! He is lost
To goodness does not honour him.

Hair. My knight!

Cel. [Aside.] This is right playing at court shuttlecock.

Re-enter Gentlewoman.

Gentlew. Madam, there is a gentleman desires
To speak wi' ye, one Sir Thomas Bornwell.

Cel. Bornwell?

Gentlew. He says he is a stranger to your ladyship.

Scent. I know him.

Hair. Your neighbour, madam.

Scent. Husband to
The lady that so revels in the Strand.

Hair. He has good parts, they say, but cannot help
His lady's bias.

Cel. They have both much fame
I' th' town, for several merits. Pray admit him.
[Exit Gentlewoman.]

Hair. [Aside.] What comes he for?

Enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL.

Born. Your pardon, noble lady, that I have
Presum'd a stranger to your knowledge, - [Salutes CELESTINA.]

Cel. Sir,
Your worth was here before you, and your person
Cannot be here ungrateful.

Born. 'T is the bounty
Of your sweet disposition, madam. - Make me
Your servant, lady, by her fair example,
To favour me. [Offers to salute ISABELLA, who turns from him.
Aside.] - I never knew one turn
Her cheek to a gentleman that came to kiss her,
But she 'd a stinking breath. - Your servant, gentlemen.
Will Scentlove, how is 't?

Cel. I am sorry, coz,
To accuse you; we in nothing more betray
Ourselves to censure of ridiculous pride,
Than answering a fair salute too rudely.
Oh, it shows ill upon a gentlewoman
Not to return the modest lip, if she
Would have the world believe her breath is not
Offensive.

Born. Madam, I have business
With you.

Scent. His looks are pleasant.

Cel. With me, sir?

Born. I hear you have an exc'llent wit, madam;

I see you are fair.

Cel. The first is but report;
And do not trust your eye-sight for the last,
'Cause I presume y' are mortal, and may err.

Hair. He is very gamesome.

Born. Y' have an exc'llent voice,
(They say you catcht it from a dying swan,)
[With] which, join'd to the harmony of your lute,
You ravish all mankind.

Cel. Ravish mankind?

Born. With their consent.

Cel. It were the stranger rape;
But there 's the less indictment lies against it:
And there is hope your little honesties[4276]
Cannot be much the worse, for men do rather
Believe they had a maidenhead, than put
Themselves to th' rack of memory how long
'T is since they left the burden of their innocence.

Born. Why, you are bitter, madam!

Cel. So is physic;
I do not know your constitution.

Born. You shall, if 't please you, madam.

Cel. Y' are too hasty,
I must examine what certificate
You have first, to prefer you.

Born. Fine! certificate?

Cel. Under your lady's hand and seal.

Born. Go to;
I see you are a wag.

Cel. But take heed how
You trust to 't.

Born. I can love you in my wedlock,
As well as that young gallant o' th' first hair,

Or the knight-bachelor; and can return
As amorous delight to thy soft bosom.

Cel. Your person and your language are both strangers.

Born. But may be more familiar; I have those
That dare make affidavit for my body.

Cel. D' ye mean your surgeon?

Born. My surgeon, madam?
I know not how you value my abilities,
But I dare undertake as much, to express
My service to your ladyship, and with
As fierce ambition fly to your commands,
As the most valiant of these lay siege to you.

Cel. You dare not, sir.

Born. How, madam?

Cel. I will justify 't.
You dare not marry me; and I imagine
Some here, should I consent, would fetch a priest
Out of the fire.

Born. I have a wife indeed.

Cel. And there 's a statute not repeal'd, I take it.

Born. Y' are in the right; I must confess y' have hit
And bled me in a master vein.

Cel. You think
I took you on the advantage; use your best
Skill at defence, I 'll come up to your valour,
And show another work you dare not do:
You dare not, sir, be virtuous.

Born. I dare,
By this fair hand I dare; and ask a pardon,
If my rude words offend your innocence,
Which, in a form so beautiful, would shine
To force a blush in them suspected it,
And from the rest draw wonder.

Hair. I like not
Their secret parley; shall I interrupt them?

Isab. By no means, sir.

Scent. Sir Thomas was not wont
To show so much a courtier.

Mar. He cannot
Be prejudicial to you; suspect not
Your own deserts so much; he 's married.

Born. I have other business, madam. You keep music:
I came to try how you can dance.

Cel. You did? - [Aside.] I 'll try his humour out of breath.
Although I boast no cunning, sir, in revels,
If you desire to show your art that way,
I can wait on you.

Born. You much honour me;
Nay, all must join to make a harmony. They dance.

Born. I have nothing now, madam, but to beseech,
After a pardon for my boldness, you
Would give occasion to pay my gratitude.
I have a house will be much honoured,
If you vouchsafe your presence; and a wife
Desires to present herself your servant.
I came with the ambition to invite you,
Deny me not; your person you shall trust
On fair security.

Cel. Sir, although I use not
This freedom with a stranger, you shall have
No cause to hold me obstinate.

Born. You grace me.
Sir William Scentlove -

Hair. I must take my leave.
You will excuse me, madam; court attendances -

Cel. By any means.

Born. Ladies, you will vouchsafe
Your company?

Isab. We wait upon you, sir. Exeunt.

ACT III

[SCENE I.][4277]

Table and looking-glass. Enter LORD - - unready.[4278] HAIRCUT preparing his periwig.

Lord. What hour is 't?

Hair. 'Bout three o'clock, my lord.

Lord. 'T is time to rise.

Hair. Your lordship went but late
To bed last night.

Lord. 'T was early in the morning.

Sec. [within.] Expect[4279] awhile, my lord is busy.

Enter Secretary.

Lord. What 's the matter?

Sec. Here is a lady
Desires access to you upon some affairs,
She says, may specially concern your lordship.

Lord. A lady? What 's her name?

Sec. Madam Decoy.

Lord. Decoy? Prithee admit her. [Exit Secretary.]
Enter DECOY.
Have you business, madam,
With me?

Dec. And such, I hope, as will not be
Offensive to your lordship.

Lord. I pray speak it.

Dec. I would desire your lordship's ear more private.

Lord. Wait i' th' next chamber till I call. - Now, madam.
Exit [HAIRCUT].

Dec. Although I am a stranger to your lordship,
I would not lose a fair occasion offer'd
To show how much I honour, and would serve you.

Lord. Please you to give me the particular,
That I may know the extent of my engagement.[4280]
I am ignorant by what desert you should
Be encourag'd to have care of me.

Dec. My lord,
I will take boldness to be plain; beside
Your other excellent parts, you have much fame
For your sweet inclination to our sex.

Lord. How d' ye mean, madam?

Dec. I' that way your lordship
Hath honourably practis'd upon some
Not to be nam'd. Your noble constancy
To a mistress hath deserv'd our general vote;
And I, a part of womankind, have thought
How to express my duty.

Lord. In what, madam?

Dec. Be not so strange, my lord. I knew the beauty
And pleasures of your eyes; that handsome creature
With whose fair life all your delight took leave,
And to whose memory you have paid too much
Sad tribute.

Lord. What 's all this?

Dec. This: if your lordship
Accept my service, in pure zeal to cure
Your melancholy, I could point where you might
Repair your loss.

Lord. Your ladyship, I conceive,
Doth traffic in flesh merchandize.

Dec. To men
Of honour, like yourself. I am well known
To some in court, and come not with ambition
Now to supplant your officer.

Lord. What is
The lady of pleasure you prefer?

Dec. A lady
Of birth and fortune, one upon whose virtue
I may presume, the lady Aretina.

Lord. Wife to Sir Thomas Bornwell?

Dec. The same, sir.

Lord. Have you prepar'd her?

Dec. Not for your lordship, till I have found your pulse.
I am acquainted with her disposition,
She has a very appliable[4281] nature.

Lord. And, madam, when expect you to be whipt
For doing these fine favours?

Dec. How, my lord?
Your lordship does but jest, I hope; you make
A difference between a lady that
Does honourable offices, and one
They call a bawd. Your lordship was not wont
To have such coarse opinion of our practice.

Lord. The Lady Aretina is my kinswoman.

Dec. What if she be, my lord? The nearer blood,
The dearer sympathy.

Lord. I 'll have thee carted.[4282]

Dec. Your lordship will not so much stain your honour
And education, to use a woman
Of my quality -

Lord. 'T is possible you may
Be sent off with an honourable convoy
Of halberdiers.

Dec. Oh, my good lord!

Lord. Your ladyship shall be no protection,
If you but stay three minutes.

Dec. I am gone. -
When next you find rebellion in your blood,
May all within ten mile o' th' court turn honest![4283] Exit.

Lord. I do not find that proneness, since the fair
Bella Maria died; my blood is cold,
Nor is there beauty enough surviving
To heighten me to wantonness. - Who waits?
Re-enter HAIRCUT [and Secretary].
And what said my lady?

Hair. The silent language of her face, my lord,
Was not so pleasant, as it show'd upon
Her entrance.

Lord. Would any man that meets
This lady take her for a bawd?

Hair. She does
The trade an honour, credit to the profession.
We may in time see baldness, quarter noses,
And rotten legs to take the wall of footcloths.

Lord. I ha' thought better; call the lady back. -
I wo' not lose this opportunity. -
Bid her not fear. [Exit Secretary.] - The favour is not common,
And I 'll reward it. I do wonder much
Will Scentlove was not here to-day.

Hair. I heard him say this morning he would wait
Upon your lordship. - She is return'd, sir.

Re-enter Secretary and DECOY.

Sec. Madam, be confident, my lord 's not angry.

Lord. You return welcome, madam; you are better
Read in your art, I hope, than to be frighted
With any shape of anger, when you bring
Such news to gentlemen. Madam, you shall
Soon understand how I accept the office.

Dec. You are the first lord, since I studied carriage,
That show'd such infidelity and fury
Upon so kind a message. Every gentleman
Will show some breeding; but if one right honourable
Should not have noble blood -

Lord. You shall return
My compliment, in a letter, to my lady
Aretina. Favour me with a little patience. -
Show her that chamber.

Dec. I 'll attend your lordship.
Exeunt [DECOY and HAIRCUT. - Secretary seats himself at a table].

Lord. Write, - "Madam, where your honour
is in danger, my love must not be silent."
Enter [Sir WILLIAM] SCENTLOVE and KICKSHAW.
Scentlove and Kickshaw!

Kick. Your lordship's busy.

Lord. Writing a letter; - nay, it sh' not bar
Any discourse.
[Walks alternately to the Secretary and to SCENTLOVE and KICKSHAW.]

Sec. "Silent."

Lord. "Though I be no physician, I may prevent a fever in your
blood."
And where have you spent the morning's conversation?

Scent. Where you would have given the best barbary
In your stable to have met on honourable terms.

Lord. What new beauty? You acquaint yourselves
With none but wonders.

Scent. 'T is too low, - a miracle.

Lord. It will require a strong faith.

Sec. "Your blood."

Lord. "If you be innocent, preserve your
fame, lest this Decoy-madam betray it, to your
repentance" -
By what name is she known?

Scent. Ask Alexander;
He knows her.

Kick. Whom?

Scent. The lady Celestina.

Lord. He has a vast knowledge of ladies. 'Las, poor Alexander!
When dost thou mean thy body shall lie fallow?

Kick. When there is mercy in a petticoat:
I must turn pilgrim for some breath.

Lord. I think
'T were cooler travel, if you examine it,
Upon the hoof through Spain.

Scent. Through Ethiopia.

Lord. Nay, less laborious to serve a prenticeship
In Peru, and dig gold out of the mine,
Though all the year were dog-days.

Sec. "To repentance."

Lord. "In brief, this lady, could you fall
from virtue, within my knowledge, will not
blush to be a bawd."

Scent. But hang 't, 't is honourable journey-work;
Thou art famous by it, and thy name 's up.

Kick. So, sir!
Let me ask you a question, my dear knight:
Which is less servile, to bring up the pheasant,
And wait, or sit at table uncontroll'd,
And carve to my own appetite?

Scent. No more;
Thou 'rt witty, as I am.

Sec. "A bawd."

Scent. How 's that?

Kick. Oh, you are famous by 't, and your name 's up, sir.

Lord. "Be wise, and reward my caution
with timely care of yourself, so I shall not
repent to be known your loving kinsman and
servant" -
Gentlemen, the lady Celestina,
Is she so rare a thing?

Kick. If you 'll have my
Opinion, my lord, I never saw
So sweet, so fair, so rich a piece of nature.

Lord. I 'll show thee a fairer presently, to shame
Thy eyes and judgment; look o' that. [Gives him a miniature.] - So;
I 'll subscribe. [Signs his name to the letter.]
Seal it; I 'll excuse your pen for the direction.

Kick. Bella Maria's picture! she was handsome.

Scent. But not to be compar'd -

Lord. Your patience, gentlemen; I 'll return instantly. Exit.

Kick. Whither is my lord gone?

Sec. To a lady i' th' next chamber.

Scent. What is she?

Sec. You shall pardon me, I am his secretary.

Scent. I was wont to be of his counsel. A new officer.
And I not know 't? I am resolv'd to batter
All other with the praise of Celestina:
I must retain him.

Re-enter Lord.

Lord. Has not that object
Convinc'd your erring judgments?

Kick. What! this picture?

Lord. Were but your thoughts as capable as mine
Of her idea, you would wish no thought
That were not active in her praise, above
All worth and memory of her sex.

Scent. She was fair,
I must confess; but had your lordship look'd
With eyes more narrow, and some less affection.
Upon her face, -

Kick. I do not love the copies
Of any dead, they make me dream of goblins;
Give me a living mistress, with but half

The beauty of Celestina. Come, my lord,
'T is pity that a lord of so much flesh
Should waste upon a ghost, when they are living
Can give you a more honourable consumption.

Scent. Why, do you mean, my lord, to live an infidel?
Do, and see what will come on 't; observe[4284] still,
And dote upon your vigils; build a chamber
Within a rock, a tomb among the worms,
Not far off, where you may, in proof apocryphal,
Court 'em not to devour the pretty pile
Of flesh your mistress carried to the grave.
There are no women in the world; all eyes,
And tongues, and lips, are buried in her coffin!

Lord. Why, do you think yourselves competent judges
Of beauty, gentlemen?

Both. What should hinder us?

Kick. I have seen and tried as many as another,
With a mortal back.

Lord. Your eyes are brib'd,
And your hearts chain'd to some desires; you cannot
Enjoy the freedom of a sense.

Kick. Your lordship
Has a clear eyesight, and can judge and penetrate.

Lord. I can, and give a perfect censure of
Each line and point; distinguish beauty from
A thousand forms, which your corrupted optics
Would pass for natural.

Scent. I desire no other
Judge should determine us, and if your lordship
Dare venture but your eyes upon this lady,
I 'll stand their justice, and be confident
You shall give Celestina victory
And triumph o'er all beauties past and living.

Kick. I dare, my lord, venture a suit of clothes,
You 'll be o'ercome.

Lord. You do not know my fortitude.

Scent. Nor frailty; you dare not trust yourself to see her.

Lord. Think you so, gentlemen? I dare see this creature
To make you know your errors, and the difference
Of her whose memory is my saint. Not trust
My senses! I dare see, and speak with her.
Which holds the best acquaintance to prepare
My visit to her?

Sent. I will do 't, my lord.

Kick. She is a lady free in entertainments.

Lord. I would give this advantage to your cause,
Bid her appear in all the ornaments
Did ever wait on beauty, all the riches
Pride can put on, and teach her face more charm
Than ever poet drest up Venus in;
Bid her be all the Graces, and the Queen
Of Love in one, I 'll see her, Scentlove, and
Bring off my heart, arm'd but [with a] single thought
Of one that 's dead, without a wound; and when
I have made your folly prisoner, I 'll laugh at you.

Scent. She shall expect you; trust to me for knowledge.

Lord. I 'm for the present somewhere else engag'd;
Let me hear from you. [Exit.]

Scent. So! I am glad he 's yet
So near conversion.

Kick. I am for Aretina.

Scent. No mention of my lord.

Kick. Prepare his lady,
'T is time he were reduc'd[4285] to the old sport;
One lord like him more would undo the court. Exeunt.

[SCENE II.][4286]

Enter LADY BORNWELL, with a letter, and DECOY.

Dec. He is the ornament of your blood, madam;
I am much bound to his lordship.

Lady B. He gives you

A noble character.

Dec. 'T is his goodness, madam.

Lady B. [Aside.] I wanted such an engine. My lord has
Done me a courtesy, to disclose her nature;
I now know one to trust, and will employ her. -
Touching my lord, for reasons which I shall
Offer to your ladyship hereafter, I
Desire you would be silent; but, to show
How much I dare be confident in your secrecy,
I pour my bosom forth. I love a gentleman,
One whom there wo' not need much conjuration
To meet. - Your ear. [Whispers her.]

Dec. I apprehend you, and I shall
Be happy to be serviceable. I am sorry
Your ladyship did not know me before now:
I have done offices: and not a few
Of the nobility but have done feats
Within my house, which is convenient
For situation, and artful chambers.
And pretty pictures to provoke the fancy.

Enter LITTLEWORTH.

Little. Madam, all pleasures languish in your absence.

Lady B. Your pardon a few minutes, sir. - You must
Contrive it thus. [Walks aside with DECOY.]

Little. I attend, and shall account it
Honour to wait on your return.

Lady B. He may not
Have the least knowledge of my name or person.

Dec. I have practis'd that already for some great ones,
And dare again, to satisfy you, madam;
I have a thousand ways to do sweet offices.

Little. If this Lady Aretina should be honest,
I ha' lost time. She 's free as air; I must
Have closer conference, and if I have art,
Make her affect me in revenge.

Dec. This evening?
Leave me to manage things.

Lady B. You will oblige me.

Dec. You shall commend my art, and thank me after. Exit.

Lady B. I hope the revels are maintain'd within?

Little. By Sir Thomas and his mistress.

Lady B. How? His mistress?

Little. The lady Celestina; I ne'er saw
Eyes shoot more amorous interchange.

Lady B. Is 't so?

Little. He wears her favour with mere[4287] pride -

Lady B. Her favour?

Little. A feather that he ravish'd from her fan;
And is so full of courtship, which she smiles on.

Lady B. 'T is well.

Little. And praises her beyond all poetry.

Lady B. I 'm glad he has so much wit.

Little. [Aside.] Not jealous!

Lady B. [Aside.] This secures me. What would make other ladies pale
With jealousy, gives but license to my wand'rings.
Let him now tax[4288] me, if he dare; and yet
Her beauty 's worth my envy, and I wish
Revenge upon it, not because he loves,
But that it shines above my own.

Enter KICKSHAW.

Kick. Dear madam!

Lady B. I have it. - You two gentlemen profess
Much service to me; if I have a way
To employ your wit and secrecy? -

Both. You 'll honour us.

Lady B. You gave a high and worthy character
Of Celestina.

Kick. I remember, madam.

Lady B. Do either of you love her?

Kick. Not I, madam.

Little. I would not, if I might.

Lady B. She 's now my guest,
And, by a trick, invited by my husband,
To disgrace me. - You, gentlemen, are held
Wits of the town, the consuls that do govern
The senate here, whose jeers are all authentic.
The taverns and the ordinaries are
Made academies, where you come, and all
Your sins and surfeits made the time's example.
Your very nods can quell a theatre,
No speech or poem good without your seal;
You can protect sourrility, and publish;
By your authority believ'd, no rapture
Ought to have honest meaning.

Kick. Leave our characters.

Little. And name the employment.

Lady B. You must exercise
The strength of both your wits upon this lady,
And talk her into humbleness or anger,
Both which are equal, to my thought. If you
Dare undertake this slight thing for my sake,
My favour shall reward it; but be faithful,
And seem to let all spring from your own freedom.

Kick. This all! We can defame her; if you please,
My friend shall call her whore, or any thing.
And never be endanger'd to a duel.

Lady B. How 's that?

Kick. He can endure a cudgelling, and no man
Will fight after so fair a satisfaction:
But leave us to our art, and do not limit us.

Lady B. They are here; begin not till I whisper you.

Enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL, CELESTINA, MARIANA, and ISABELLA.

Lady B. Je vous prie, madame, d'excuser l'importunité de mes affaires, qui m'ont fait offenser, par mon absence, une dame de laquelle j'ai reçu tant d'obligations.

Cel. Pardonnez moi, madame; vous me faites trop d'honneur.

Lady B. C'est bien de la douceur de votre naturel, que vous tenez cette langage; mais j'espère que mon mari n'a pas manqué de vous entretenir en mon absence.

Cel. En vérité, monsieur nous a fort obligé.

Lady B. Il eût trop failli, s'il n'eut taché de tout son pouvoir à vous rendre toutes sortes de services.

Cel. C'est de sa bonté qu'il nous a tant favorise.

Lady B. De la vôtre plutôt, madame, que vous fait donner d'interprétation si bénigne à ses efforts.

Cel. Je vois bien que la victoire sera toujours à madame, et de langage et de la courtesie.

Lady B. Vraiment, madame, que jamais personne a plus désiré l'honneur de votre compagnie que moi.

Cel. Laissons-en, je vous supplie, des complimens, et permettez à votre servante de vous baiser les mains.

Lady B. Vous m'obligez trop.

Born. I have no more patience; let 's be merry again
In our own language: madam, our mirth cools.
Our nephew!

Enter FREDERICK [intoxicated, and Steward].

Lady B. Passion of my brain!

Fred. Save you, gentlemen! save you, ladies!

Lady B. I am undone.

Fred. I must salute; no matter at which end I begin. [Salutes

CELESTINA.]

Lady B. There's a compliment!

Cel. Is this your nephew, madam?

Lady B. Je vous prie, madame, d'excuser les habits et le rude
comportement de mon cousin. Il est tout fraîchement venu de
l'université, où on l'a tout gâté.

Cel. Excusez moi, madame, il est bien accompli.

Fred. This language should be French by the motions of your heads,
and the mirth of your faces.

Lady B. I am dishonour'd.

Fred. 'T is one of the finest tongues for ladies to show their
teeth in: if you 'll Latin it, I am for you, or Greek it; my tailor
has not put me into French yet. Mille basia, basia mille.

Cel. Je ne vous entends pas, monsieur;
I understand you not, sir.

Fred. Why, so!
You and I then shall be in charity;
For though we should be abusive, we ha' the benefit
Not to understand one another. Where 's my aunt?
I did hear music somewhere; and my brains,
Tun'd with a bottle of your capering claret,
Made haste to show their dancing.

Little. Please you, madam,
[Offering his box of sweetmeats to CELESTINA.]
They are very uncomfortable.[4289]

Stew. Alas, madam,
How would you have me help it? I did use
All means I could, after he heard the music,
To make him drunk, in hope so to contain him;
But the wine made him lighter, and his head
Flew hither, ere I mist his heels.

Kick. Nay, he spoke Latin to the lady.

Lady B. O most unpardonable! Get him off
Quickly, and discreetly too; or, if I live - -

Stew. It is not in my power; he swears I am
An absurd sober fellow; and if you keep
A servant in his house to cross his humour,
When the rich sword and belt comes home, he 'll kill him.

Lady B. What shall I do? Try your skill, Master Littleworth.

Little. He has ne'er a sword. - Sweet master Frederick -

Born. 'Tis pity, madam, such a scion should
Be lost; - but you are clouded.

Cel. Not I, sir,
I never found myself more clear at heart.

Born. I could play with a feather; your fan, lady. -
Gentlemen, Aretina, ta, ra, ra, ra! Come, madam.

Fred. Why, my good tutor in election,
You might have been a scholar.

Little. But I thank
My friends, they brought me up a little better.
Give me the town wits, that deliver jests
Clean from the bow, that whistle in the air,
And cleave the pin at twelvescore! Ladies do
But laugh at a gentleman that has any learning;
'T is sin enough to have your clothes suspected.
Leave us, and I will find a time to instruct you.
Come, here are sugar plums; 't is a good Frederick.

Fred. Why, is not this my aunt's house in the Strand?
The noble rendezvous? Who laughs at me?
Go, I will root here if I list, and talk
Of rhetoric, logic, Latin, Greek, or any thing,
And understand 'em too; who says the contrary?
Yet, in a fair way, I contemn all learning,
And will be as ignorant as he, or he,
Or any taffeta, satin, scarlet, plush.
Tissue, or cloth o' bodkin[4290] gentleman.
Whose manners are most gloriously infected. - -
Did you laugh at me, lady?

Cel. Not I, sir;
But if I did show mirth upon your question,
I hope you would not beat me, little gentleman?

Fred. How! "little gentleman?" You dare not say

These words to my new clothes, and fighting sword.

Lady B. Nephew Frederick!

Fred. "Little gentleman!"
'T is an affront both to my blood and person,
I am a gentleman of as tall a birth
As any boast[4291] nobility; though my clothes
Smell o' the lamp, my coat is honourable,
Right honourable, full of or and argent.- - -
A "little gentleman!"

Born. Coz, you must be patient;
My lady meant you no dishonour, and
You must remember she 's a woman.

Fred. Is she a woman? That 's another matter. -
Do you hear? My uncle tells me what you are.

Cel. So, sir.

Fred. You call'd me "little gentleman."

Cel. I did, sir.

Fred. A little pink[4292] has made a lusty ship
Strike her top-sail; the crow may beard the elephant,
A whelp may tame the tiger, spite of all
False decks and murderers;[4293] and a "little gentleman"
Be hard enough to grapple with your ladyship,
Top and top-gallant. - Will you go drink, uncle,
T' other enchanted bottle? You and I
Will tipple, and talk philosophy.

Born. Come, nephew. -
You will excuse a minute's absence, madam. -
Wait you on us.

Stew. My duty, sir.
Exeunt SIR THOMAS BORNWELL, FREDERICK, and Steward.

Lady B. Now, gentlemen.

Kick. Madam, I had rather you excuse my language
For speaking truth, than virtue suffer in
My further silence; and it is my wonder
That you, whose noble carriage hath deserv'd
All honour and opinion, should now

Be guilty of ill manners.

Cel. What was that
You told me, sir?

Little. Do you not blush, madam,
To ask that question?

Cel. You amaze rather
My cheek to paleness. What mean you by this?
I am not troubled with the hiccup, gentlemen,
You should bestow this fright upon me.

Little. Then
Pride and ill memory go together.

Cel. How, sir?

Kick. The gentleman on whom you exercis'd
Your thin wit, was a nephew to the lady
Whose guest you are; and though her modesty
Look calm on the abuse of one so near
Her blood, the affront was impious.

Little. I am asham'd on t.
You an ingenious lady, and well manner'd!
I 'll teach a bear as much civility.

Cel. You may be master of the college, sir,
For aught I know.

Little. What college?

[Cel.][4294] Of the bears.
Have you a plot upon me? Do you possess
Your wits, or know me, gentlemen?

Re-enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL, [behind].

Born. How 's this?

Kick. Know you? Yes; we do know you to an atom.

Little. Madam, we know what stuff your soul is made on.

Cel. But do not bark so like a mastiff, pray. - -
Sure they are mad. - Let your brains stand awhile,
And settle, gentlemen; you know not me;

What am I?

Little. Th' art a puppet, a thing made
Of clothes and painting, and not half so handsome
As that which play'd Susanna in the fair.

Cel. I heard you visited those canvas tragedies,
One of their constant audience, and so taken
With Susan, that you wish'd yourself a rival
With the two wicked elders.

Kick. You think this
Is wit now. Come, you are -

Cel. What, I beseech you?
Your character will be full of salt and satire,
No doubt. What am I?

Kick. Why, you are a woman -

Cel. And that 's at least a bow wide of your knowledge.

Kick. Would be thought handsome, and might pass i' th' country
Upon a market day; but so miserably
Forfeit to pride and fashions, that if Heaven
Were a new gown, you'd not stay in 't a fortnight.

Cel. It must be miserably out of fashion then.
Have I no sin but pride?

Kick. Hast any virtue,
Or but a good face, to excuse that want?

Cel. You prais'd it yesterday.

Kick. That made you proud.

Cel. More pride!

Kick. You need not: - to close up the praise,
I have seen a better countenance in a sybil.

Cel. When you wore spectacles of sack,[4295] mistook
The painted cloth,[4296] and kist it for your mistress.

Kick. Let me ask you a question; how much
Have you consum'd in expectation
That I would love you?

Cel. Why, I think as much
As you have paid away in honest debts
This seven year. 'T is a pretty impudence,
But cannot make me angry.

Little. Is there any
Man that will cast away his limbs upon her?

Kick. You do not sing so well as I imagin'd,
Nor dance; you reel in your coranto,[4297] and pinch
Your petticoat too hard: y' have no good ear
To th' music, and incline too much one shoulder,
As you were dancing on the rope, and falling.
You speak abominable French, and make
A curtsey like a dairy-maid. - [Aside.] Not mad!

Little. Do we not sting her handsomely?

Born. A conspiracy!

Kick. Your state is not so much as 't is reported,
When you confer notes, all your husband's debts,
And your own reconcil'd; but that 's not it
Will so much spoil your marriage.

Cel. As what, sir?
Let me know all my faults.

Kick. Some men do whisper
You are not over honest.[4298]

Cel. All this shall not
Move me to more than laughter, and some pity,
Because you have the shapes of gentlemen;
And though you have been insolent upon me,
I will engage no friend to kick or cudgel you,
To spoil your living and your limbs together:
I leave that to diseases that offend you,
And spare my curse, poor silken vermin! and
Hereafter shall distinguish men from monkeys.

Born. [coming forward.] Brave soul! - You brace of
horse-leeches! - I have heard
Their barbarous language, madam; y' are too merciful:
They shall be silent to your tongue; pray punish 'em.

Cel. They are things not worth my character,[4299] nor mention

Of any clean breath; so lost in honesty,
They cannot satisfy for wrongs enough,
Though they should steal out of the world at Tyburn.[4300]

Little. We are hang'd already.

Cel. Yet I will talk a little to the pilchards. - [4301]
You two, that have not 'twixt you both the hundred
Part of a soul, coarse woollen-witted fellows,
Without a nap, with bodies made for burdens!
You, that are only stuffings for apparel,
As you were made but engines[4302] for your tailors
To frame their clothes upon, and get them custom,
Until men see you move; yet, then you dare not,
Out of your guilt[4303] of being the ignobler beast,
But give a horse the wall, whom you excel
Only in dancing of the brawls,[4304] because
The horse was not taught the French way. Your two faces,
One fat, like Christmas, t' other lean, like Candlemas,
And prologue to a Lent, both bound together,
Would figure Janus, and do many cures
On agues, and the green disease,[4305] by frighting;
But neither can, with all the characters
And conjuring circles, charm a woman, though
She 'd fourscore years upon her, and but one
Tooth in her head, to love, or think well of you:
And I were miserable to be at cost
To court such a complexion as your malice
Did impudently insinuate. But I waste time,
And stain my breath in talking to such tadpoles.
Go home, and wash your tongues in barley-water,
Drink[4306] clean tobacco, be not hot i' th' mouth,
And you may scape the beadle; so I leave you
To shame, and your own garters! - Sir, I must
Entreat you, for my honour, do not penance them,
They are not worth your anger. How shall I
Acquit your lady's silence?

Born. Madam, I
Am sorry to suspect, and dare revenge.

Cel. No cause of mine.

Born. It must become me to attend you home.

Cel. You are noble. - Farewell, mushrooms.
[Exit with SIR THOMAS BORNWELL.]

Lady B. Is she gone?

Little. I think we pepper'd her.

Kick. I 'm glad 't is over;
But I repent no service for you, madam. -
Enter Servant, with a letter [and a jewel, which he delivers to
KICKSHAW].
To me? From whence? - A jewel! a good preface.
Be happy the conclusion. He smiles upon 't.

Lady B. Some love letter.

Little. He has a hundred mistresses: you may
Be charitable, madam, I ha' none;
He surfeits, and I fall away i' th' kidneys.

Kick. I 'll meet. - [Exit Servant.]
[Aside.] 'T is some great lady, questionless, that has
Taken notice, and would satisfy her appetite.

Lady B. Now, Master Alexander, you look bright o' the sudden;
Another spirit 's in your eye.

Kick. Not mine, madam;
Only a summons to meet a friend.

Lady B. What friend?

Little. By this jewel, I know her not.

Lady B. 'T is a she-friend. I 'll follow, gentlemen;
We may have a game at cent[4307] before you go.

Kick. I shall attend you, madam.

Little. 'T is our duty.
[Exeunt KICKSHAW and LITTLEWORTH.]

Lady B. I blush while I converse with my own thoughts.
Some strange fate governs me, but I must on;
The ways are cast already, and we thrive
When our sin fears no eye nor perspective. Exit.

ACT IV

[SCENE I.][4308]

Enter two men leading KICKSHAW blinded, and go off suddenly.

Kick. I am not hurt; my patience to obey 'em,
Not without fear to ha' my throat cut else,
Did me a courtesy. Whither ha' they brought me?
[Pulls off a bandage.]
'T is devilish dark; the bottom of a well
At midnight, with but two stars on the top,
Were broad day to this darkness. I but think
How like a whirlwind these rogues caught me up,
And smothered my eyesight. Let me see,
These may be spirits, and, for aught I know,
Have brought me hither over twenty steeples.
Pray Heaven they were not bailiffs! that 's more worth
My fear, and this a prison. All my debts
Reek in my nostril, and my bones begin
To ache with fear to be made dice; and yet
This is too calm and quiet for a prison. -
What if the riddle prove I am robb'd? And yet
I did not feel 'em search me. How now! music! [Music within.]
Enter DECOY, like an old Woman, with a light.
And a light! What beldam 's this? I cannot pray. -
What art?

Dec. A friend. Fear not, young man, I am
No spirit.

Kick. Off!

Dec. Despise me not for age,
Or this coarse outside, which I wear not out
Of poverty. Thy eyes be witness, 't is
No cave, or beggar's cell, th' art brought to; let
That gold speak here 's no want, which thou mayst spend,
And find a spring to tire even prodigality,
If thou be'st wise. [Gives him a purse.]

Kick. The devil was a coiner
From the beginning; yet the gold looks current.

Dec. Th' art still in wonder: know, I am mistress of
This house, and of a fortune that shall serve
And feed thee with delights; 't was I sent for thee;
The jewel and the letter came from me.

It was my art thus to contrive our meeting,
Because I would not trust thee with my fame,
Until I found thee worth a woman's honour.

Kick [Aside.] Honour and fame! the devil means to have
A care on 's credit. Though she sent for me,
I hope she has another customer
To do the trick withal; I would not turn
Familiar to a witch.

Dec. What say'st? Canst thou
Dwell in my arms to-night? Shall we change kisses,
And entertain the silent hours with pleasure,
Such as old Time shall be delighted with,
And blame the too swift motion of his wings,
While we embrace?

Kick. [Aside.] Embrace! She has had no teeth
This twenty years, and the next violent cough
Brings up her tongue; it cannot possibly
Be sound at root. I do not think but one
Strong sneeze upon her, and well meant, would make
Her quarters fall away; one kick would blow
Her up like gunpowder, and loose all her limbs.
She is so cold, an incubus would not heat her;
Her phlegm would quench a furnace, and her breath
Would damp a musket bullet.

Dec. Have you, sir,
Consider'd?

Kick. What?

Dec. My proposition.
Canst love?

Kick. I could have done; whom do you mean?
I know you are pleas'd but to make sport.

Dec. Thou art not
So dull of soul as thou appear'st.

Kick. [Aside.] This is
But some device; my grannam has some trick in 't. -
Yes, I can love.

Dec. But canst thou affect me?

Kick. Although to reverence so grave a matron
Were an ambitious word in me, yet since
You give me boldness, I do love you.

Dec. Then
Thou art my own.

Kick. [Aside.] Has she no cloven foot?

Dec. And I am thine, and all that I command
Thy servants; from this minute thou art happy,
And fate in thee will crown all my desires.
I griev'd a proper man should be compell'd
To bring his body to the common market.
My wealth shall make thee glorious; and, the more
To encourage thee, howe'er this form may fright
Thy youthful eyes, yet thou wo't find, by light
Of thy own sense, for other light is banish'd
My chamber, when our arms tie lovers' knots,
And kisses seal the welcome of our lips,
I shall not there affright thee, nor seem old,
With rivell'd[4309] veins; my skin is smooth and soft
As ermines, with a spirit to meet thine,
Active, and equal to the Queen of Love's
When she did court Adonis.

Kick. [Aside.] This doth more
Confirm she is a devil, and I am
Within his own dominions. I must on,
Or else be torn, a' pieces. I have heard
These succubae must not be crost.

Dec. We trifle
Too precious time away; I'll show you a prospect
Of the next chamber, and then out the candle.

Kick. Have you no sack i' th' house? I would go arm'd
Upon this breach.

Dec. It sh' not need.

Kick. One word.
Mother; have not you been a cat in your days?

Dec. I am glad you are so merry, sir. You observe
That bed? [Opens a door.]

Kick. A very brave one.

Dec. When you are
Disrob'd, you can come thither in the dark.
You sha' not stay for me? Come, as you wish
For happiness. Exit.

Kick. I am preferr'd, if I
Be modest and obey: she cannot have
The heart to do me harm, an she were Hecate
Herself. I will have a strong faith, and think
I march upon a mistress, the less evil.
If I scape fire now, I defy the devil. Exit.

[SCENE II.][4310]

Enter FREDERICK [gaily dressed,] LITTLEWORTH, and Steward.

Fred. And how d'ye like me now?

Stew. Most excellent.

Fred. Your opinion, Master Littleworth.

Little. Your French tailor
Has made you a perfect gentleman; I may
Converse now with you, and preserve my credit.
D'ye find no alteration in your body
With these new clothes?

Fred. My body alter'd? No.

Little. You are not yet in fashion then. That must
Have a new motion, garb, and posture too,
Or all your pride is cast away; it is not
The cut of your apparel makes a gallant,
But the geometrical wearing of your clothes.

Stew. Master Littleworth tells you right; you wear your hat
Too like a citizen.

Little. 'T is like a midwife;
Place it with best advantage of your hair.
Is half your feather moulted? This does make
No show; it should spread over, like a canopy;
Your hot-rein'd monsieur wears it for a shade
And cooler to his back. Your doublet must
Be more unbutton'd hereabouts; you'll not

Be a sloven else, a foul shirt is no blemish;
You must be confident, and outface clean linen.
Your doublet and your breeches must be allow'd
No private meeting here: your cloak's too long.
It reaches to your buttock, and doth smell
Too much of Spanish gravity; the fashion
Is to wear nothing but a cape; a coat
May be allow'd a covering for one elbow,
And some, to avoid the trouble, choose to walk
In querpo,[4311] thus.

Stew. [Aside.] Your coat and cloak's a brushing
In Long-Lane, Lombard.[4312]

Fred. But what if it rain?

Little. Your belt about your shoulder is sufficient
To keep off any storm; beside, a reed
But wav'd discreetly, has so many pores,
It sucks up all the rain that falls about one.
With this defence, when other men have been
Wet to the skin through all their cloaks, I have
Defied a tempest, and walk'd by the taverns
Dry as a bone.

Stew. [Aside.] Because he had no money
To call for wine.

Fred. Why, do you walk enchanted?
Have you such pretty charms in town? But stay;
Who must I have to attend me?

Little. Is not that
Yet thought upon?

Stew. I have laid out[4313] for servants.

Little. They are everywhere.

Stew. I cannot yet be furnish'd
With such as I would put into his hands.

Fred. Of what condition must they be, and how
Many in number, sir?

Little. Beside your fencing,
Your singing, dancing, riding, and French master,
Two may serve domestic, to be constant waiters

Upon a gentleman; a fool, a pimp.

Stew. For these two officers I have enquir'd,
And I am promis'd a convenient whiskin.[4314]
I could save charges, and employ the pie-wench.
That carries her intelligence in whitepots;[4315]
Or 't is but taking order[4316] with the woman
That [trolls][4317] the ballads, she could fit him with
A concubine to any tune; but I
Have a design to place a fellow with him
That has read all Sir Pandarus' works; a Trojan[4318]
That lies conceal'd, and is acquainted with
Both city and suburban fripperies,[4319]
Can fetch 'em with a spell at midnight to him,
And warrant which are for his turn; can, for
A need, supply the surgeon too.

Fred. I like thy providence;[4320] such a one deserves
A livery twice a year.

Stew. It sha' not need; a cast suit of your worship's
Will serve; he'll find a cloak to cover it,
Out of his share with those he brings to bed to you.

Fred. But must I call this fellow pimp?

Little. It is
Not necessary; [Tom,] or Jack, or Harry,
Or what he 's known abroad by, will sound better,
That men may think he is a Christian.

Fred. But hear you, Master Littleworth: is there not
A method and degrees of title in
Men of this art?

Little. According to the honour
Of men that do employ 'em. An emperor
May give this office to a duke; a king
May have his viceroy to negociate for him;
A duke may use a lord; the lord a knight,
A knight may trust a gentleman; and when
They are abroad, and merry, gentlemen
May pimp to one another.

Fred. Good, good fellowship!
But for the fool now, that should wait on me,
And break me jests?

Little. A fool is necessary.

Stew. By any[4321] means.

Fred. But which of these two servants
Must now take place?[4322]

Little. That question, Master Frederick,
The school of heraldry should conclude upon:
But if my judgment may be heard, the fool
Is your first man; and it is known a point
Of state to have a fool.

Stew. But, sir, the other
Is held the finer servant; his employments
Are full of trust, his person clean and nimble,
And none so soon can leap into preferment,
Where fools are poor.

Little. Not all; there's story for't;
Princes have been no wiser than they should be.
Would any nobleman, that were no fool,
Spend all in hope of the philosopher's stone,
To buy new lordships in another country?
Would knights build colleges, or gentlemen
Of good estates challenge the field, and fight,
Because a whore wo' not be honest? Come,
Fools are a family over all the world;
We do affect one naturally; indeed
The fool is leiger[4323] with us.

Stew. Then the pimp
Is extraordinary.

Fred. Do not you fall out
About their places. - Here's my noble aunt!

Enter LADY BORNWELL.

Little. How do you like your nephew, madam, now?

Lady B. Well! - Turn about, Frederick. -
Very well!

Fred. Am I not now a proper gentleman?
The virtue of rich clothes! Now could I take
The wall of Julius Caesar, or affront
Great Pompey's upper lip, and defy the senate.

Nay, I can be as proud as your own heart, madam,
You may take that for your comfort; I put on
That virtue with my clothes, and I doubt not
But in a little time I shall be impudent
As any page, or player's boy. I am
Beholding to this gentleman's good discipline;
But I shall do him credit in my practice.
Your steward has some pretty notions, too,
In moral mischief.

Lady B. Your desert in this
Exceeds all other service, and shall bind me
Both to acknowledge and reward.

Little. Sweet madam,
Think me but worth your favour; I would creep
Upon my knees to honour you, and for every
Minute you lend to my reward, I'll pay
A year of serviceable tribute.

Lady B. You
Can compliment.

Little. (Aside.) Thus still she puts me off;
Unless I speak the downright word, she'll never
Understand me. A man would think that creeping
Upon one's knees were English to a lady.

Enter KICKSHAW.

Kick. How is't, Jack. - Pleasures attend you, madam!
How does my plant of honour?

Lady B. Who is this?

Kick. 'T is Alexander.

Lady B. Rich and glorious!

Little. 'T is Alexander the Great.

Kick. And my Bucephalus
Waits at the door.

Lady B. Your case is alter'd, sir.

Kick. I cannot help these things, the Fates will have it;
'T is not my land does this.

Little. But thou hast a plough
That brings it in.

Lady B. Now he looks brave and lovely.

Fred. Welcome, my gallant Macedonian,

Kick. Madam, you gave your nephew for my pupil.
I read[4324] but in a tavern; if you'll honour us,
The Bear at the Bridge foot shall entertain you.
A drawer[4325] is my Ganymede, he shall skink[4326]
Brisk nectar to us; we will only have
A dozen partridge in a dish; as many pheasants,
Quails, cocks, and godwits shall come marching up
Like the train'd-band;[4327] a fort of sturgeon
Shall give most bold defiance to an army,
And triumph o'er the table. -

Lady B. Sir, it will
But dull the appetite to hear more, and mine
Must be excus'd. Another time I may be
Your guest.

Kick. 'T is grown in fashion now with ladies;
When you please, I 'll attend you. Littleworth. -
Come, Frederick.

Fred. We 'll have music; I love noise.
We will outroar the Thames, and shake the bridge, boy.
Exit [with KICKSHAW].

Little. Madam, I kiss your hand; would you would think
Of your poor servant: flesh and blood is frail,
And troublesome to carry, without help.

Lady B. A coach will easily convey it, or
You may take water at Strand Bridge.

Little. But I
Have taken fire.

Lady B. The Thames will cool [it, sir].

Little. But never quench my heart; your charity
Can only do that.

Lady B. I will keep it cold

Of purpose.

Little. Now you bless me, and I dare
Be drunk in expectation. [Exit.]

Lady B. I am confident
He knows me not, and I were worse than mad
To be my own betrayer. - Here 's my husband.

Enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL.

Born. Why, how now, Aretina? What! alone?
The mystery of this solitude? My house
Turn desert o' the sudden! All the gamesters
Blown up! Why is the music put to silence?
Or have their instruments caught a cold, since we
Gave 'em the last heat? I must know thy ground
Of melancholy.

Lady B. You are merry, as
You came from kissing Celestina.

Born. I
Feel her yet warm upon my lip; she is
Most excellent company: I did not think
There was that sweetness in her sex. I must
Acknowledge, 't was thy cure to disenchant me
From a dull husband to an active lover.
With such a lady I could spend more years
Than since my birth my glass hath run soft minutes,
And yet be young; her presence hath a spell
To keep off age; she has an eye would strike
Fire through an adamant.

Lady B. I have heard as much
Bestow'd upon a dull-fac'd chambermaid,
Whom love and wit would thus commend. True beauty
Is mock'd when we compare thus, itself being
Above what can be fetch'd[4328] to make it lovely;
Or,[4329] could our thoughts reach something to declare
The glories of a face, or body's elegance
(That touches but our sense), when beauty spreads
Over the soul, and calls up understanding
To look [what][4330] thence is offer'd, and admire!
In both I must acknowledge Celestina
Most excellently fair, fair above all
The beauties I ha' seen, and one most worthy
Man's love and wonder.

Born. Do you speak, Aretina,
This with a pure sense to commend? Or is 't
The mockery of my praise?

Lady B. Although it shame
Myself, I must be just, and give her all
The excellency of women; and were I
A man -

Born. What then?

Lady B. I know not with what loss
I should attempt her love. She is a piece
So angelically moving, I should think
Frailty excus'd to dote upon her form,
And almost virtue to be wicked with her. Exit.

Born. What should this mean? This is no jealousy,
Or she believes I counterfeit. I feel
Something within me, like a heat, to give
Her cause, would Celestina but consent.
What a frail thing is man! It is not worth
Our glory to be chaste, while we deny
Mirth and converse with women. He is good
That dares the tempter, yet corrects his blood. Exit.

[SCENE III.][4331]

[Enter] CELESTINA, MARIANA, and ISABELLA.

Cel. I have told you all my knowledge: since he is pleas'd
To invite himself, he shall be entertain'd,
And you shall be my witnesses.

Mar. Who comes with him?

Cel. Sir William Scentlove, that prepar'd me for
The honourable encounter. I expect
His lordship every minute.

Enter SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE.

Scent. My lord is come.

Cel. He has honour'd me.

Enter Lord - and HAIRCUT.

Scent. My Lord, your periwig is awry.

Lord. You, sir -
While HAIRCUT is busy about his hair, SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE goes to CELESTINA.

Scent. You may guess at the gentleman that 's with him.
It is his barber, madam, d' ye observe?
An your ladyship wants a shaver.

Hair. She is here, sir.
I am betray'd. - Scentlove, your plot. I may
Have opportunity to be reveng'd. Exit.

Scent. She in the midst.

Lord. She 's fair, I must confess;
But does she keep this distance out of state?

Cel. Though I am poor in language to express
How much your lordship honours me, my heart
Is rich and proud in such a guest. I shall
Be out of love with every air abroad,
And for his grace done my unworthy house,
Be a fond prisoner, become anchorite,
And spend my hours in prayer, to reward
The blessing and the bounty of this presence.

Lord. Though you could turn each place you move in to
A temple, rather than a wall should hide
So rich a beauty from the world, it were
Less want to lose our piety and your prayer.
A throne were fitter to present you to
Our wonder, whence your eyes, more worth than all
They look on, should chain every heart a prisoner.

Scent. 'T was pretty well come off.

Lord. By your example
I shall know how to compliment; in this,
You more confirm my welcome.

Cel. I shall love
My lips the better, if their silent language
Persuade your lordship but to think so truly.

Lord. You make me smile, madam.

Cel. I hope you came not
With fear that any sadness here should shake
One blossom from your eye. I should be miserable
To present any object should displease you.

Lord. You do not, madam.

Cel. As I should account
It no less sorrow, if your lordship should
Lay too severe a censure on my freedom.
I wo' not court a prince against his justice,
Nor bribe him with a smile to think me honest.
Pardon, my lord, this boldness, and the mirth
That may flow from me. I believe my father
Thought of no winding-sheet when he begot me.

Lord. She has a merry soul. - It will become
Me ask your pardon, madam, for my rude
Approach, so much a stranger to your knowledge.

Cel. Not, my lord, so much stranger to my knowledge;
Though I have but seen your person afar off,
I am acquainted with your character,
Which I have heard so often, I can speak it.

Lord. You shall do me an honour.

Cel. If your lordship will
Be patient.

Lord. And glad to hear my faults.

Cel. That as your conscience can agree upon 'em;
However, if your lordship give me privilege,
I'll tell you what's the opinion of the world.

Lord. You cannot please me better.

Cel. Y'are a lord
Born with as much nobility as would,
Divided, serve to make ten noblemen,
Without a herald; but with so much spirit
And height of soul, as well might furnish twenty.
You are learn'd, a thing not compatible now
With native honour; and are master of
A language that doth chain all ears,[4332] and charm

All hearts, where you persuade; a wit so flowing,
And prudence to correct it, that all men
Believe they only meet in you, which, with
A spacious memory, make up the full wonders:
To these you have [joined][4333] valour and upon
A noble cause, know how to use a sword
To honour's best advantage, though you wear[4334] none.
You are as bountiful as the showers that fall
Into the spring's green bosom; as you were
Created lord of Fortune, not her steward;
So constant to the cause in which you make
Yourself an advocate, you dare all dangers;
And men had rather you should be their friend,
Than justice or the bench bound up together.

Lord. But did you hear all this?

Cel. And more, my lord.

Lord. Pray let me have it, madam.

Cel. To all these virtues there is added one, -
(Your lordship will remember, when I name it,
I speak but what I gather from the voice
Of others) - it is grown to a full fame
That you have lov'd a woman.

Lord. But one, madam?

Cel. Yes, many; give me leave to smile, my lord,
I shall not need to interpret in what sense;
But you have show'd yourself right honourable,
And, for your love to ladies, have deserv'd,
If their vote might prevail, a marble statue.
I make no comment on the people's text, -
My lord, I should be sorry to offend.

Lord. You cannot, madam; these are things we owe
To nature for.

Cel. And honest men will pay
Their debts.

Lord. If they be able, or compound.

Cel. She had a hard heart would be unmerciful,
And not give day to men so promising;
But you ow'd women nothing.

Lord. Yes, I am
Still in their debt, and I must owe them love,
It was part of my character.

Cel. With your lordship's
Pardon, I only said you had a fame
For loving women; but of late, men say
You have, against the imperial laws of love,
Restrain'd the active flowings of your blood,
And with a mistress buried all that is
Hop'd for in love's succession, as all beauty
Had died with her, and left the world benighted!
In this you more dishonour all our sex
Than you did grace a part; when everywhere
Love tempts your eye to admire a glorious harvest,
And everywhere as full blown ears submit
Their golden heads, the laden trees bow down
Their willing fruit, and court your amorous tasting.

Lord. I see men would dissect me to a fibre;
But do you believe this?

Cel. It is my wonder,
I must confess, a man of nobler earth
Than goes to vulgar composition,
(Born and bred high, so unconfin'd, so rich
In fortunes, and so read in all that sum
Up human knowledge, to feed gloriously,
And live at court, the only sphere wherein
True beauty moves, nature's most wealthy garden,
Where every blossom is more worth than all
The Hesperian fruit by jealous dragon watch'd,
Where all delights do circle appetite,
And pleasures multiply by being tasted,)
Should be so lost with thought of one turn'd ashes.
There's nothing left, my lord, that can excuse you,
Unless you plead, what I am asham'd to prompt
Your wisdom to?

Lord. What 's that?

Cel. That you have play'd
The surgeon with yourself.

Lord. And am made eunuch?

Cel. It were much pity.

Lord. Trouble not yourself,
I could convince your fears with demonstration
That I am man enough, but knew not where,
Until this meeting, beauty dwelt. The court
You talk'd of must be where the Queen of Love is,
Which moves but with your person; in your eye
Her glory shines, and only at that flame
Her wanton boy doth light his quick'ning torch.

Cel. Nay, now you compliment; I would it did,
My lord, for your own sake.

Lord. You would be kind,
And love me then?

Cel. My lord, I should be loving,
Where I found worth to invite it, and should cherish
A constant man.

Lord. Then you should me, madam.

Cel. But is the ice about your heart fallen off?
Can you return to do what love commands? -
Cupid, thou shalt have instant sacrifice,
And I dare be the priest.

Lord. Your hand, your lip; [Kisses her.]
Now I am proof 'gainst all temptation.

Cel. Your meaning, my good lord?

Lord. I, that have strength
Against thy voice and beauty, after this
May dare the charms of womankind. - Thou art,
Bella Maria, unprofaned yet;
This magic has no power upon my blood. -
Farewell, madam! if you durst be the example
Of chaste as well as fair, thou wert a brave one.

Cel. I hope your lordship means not this for earnest;
Be pleas'd to grace a banquet.

Lord. Pardon, madam. -
Will Scentlove, follow; I must laugh at you.

Cel. My lord, I must beseech you stay, for honour,
For her whose memory you love best.

Lord. Your pleasure.

Cel. And by that virtue you have now profest,
I charge you to believe me too; I can
Now glory that you have been worth my trial,
Which, I beseech you, pardon. Had not you
So valiantly recover'd in this conflict,
You had been my triumph, without hope of more
Than my just scorn upon your wanton flame;
Nor will I think these noble thoughts grew first
From melancholy, for some female loss,
As the fantastic world believes, but from
Truth, and your love of innocence, which shine
So bright in the two royal luminaries[4335]
At court, you cannot lose your way to chastity.
Proceed, and speak of me as honour guides you. Exit LORD.
I am almost tir'd. - Come, ladies, we 'll beguile
Dull time, and take the air another while. Exeunt.

ACT V

[SCENE I.][4336]

Enter Lady BORNWELL, and a Servant [with a purse].

Lady B. But hath Sir Thomas lost five hundred pounds
Already?

Serv. And five hundred more he borrow'd.
The dice are notable devourers, madam;
They make no more of pieces than of pebbles,
But thrust their heaps together, to engender.
"Two hundred more the caster!"[4337] cries this gentleman.
"I am wi' ye. - I ha' that to nothing, sir. The caster
Again." 'T is covered, and the table too,
With sums that frighted me. Here one sneaks out,
And with a martyr's patience smiles upon
His money's executioner, the dice;
Commands a pipe of good tobacco, and
I' th' smoke on 't vanishes. Another makes
The bones vault o'er his head, swears that ill-throwing
Has put his shoulder out of joint, calls for
A bone-setter. That looks to th' box, to bid

His master send him some more hundred pounds,
Which lost, he takes tobacco, and is quiet.
Here a strong arm throws in and in, with which
He brusheth all the table, pays the rooks[4338]
That went their smelts[4339] a piece upon his hand,
Yet swears he has not drawn a stake this seven year.
But I was bid make haste; my master may
Lose this five hundred pounds ere I come thither. Exit.

Lady B. If we both waste so fast, we shall soon find
Our state is not immortal. Something in
His other ways appear not well ready.

Enter Sir THOMAS BORNWELL, [and Servants, one with a purse.]

Born. Ye tortoises, why make ye no more haste?
Go pay to th' master of the house that money,
And tell the noble gamesters I have another
Superfluous thousand pound; at night I 'll visit 'em.
D' ye hear?

Serv. Yes, an please you.

Born. Do 't ye drudges [Exeunt Servants.]
Ta, ra, ra! - Aretina!

Lady B. You have a pleasant humour, sir.

Born. What! should a gentleman be sad?

Lady B. You have lost -

Born. A transitory sum; as good that way
As another.

Lady B. Do you not vex within for 't?

Born. I had rather lose a thousand more, than one
Sad thought come near my heart for 't. Vex for trash!
Although it go from other men like drops
Of their life blood, we lose with the alacrity
We drink a cup of sack, or kiss a mistress.
No money is considerable with a gamester;
They have souls more spacious than kings. Did two
Gamesters divide the empire of the world,
They 'd make one throw for 't all, and he that lost
Be no more melancholy than to have play'd for
A morning's draught. Vex a rich soul for dirt,

The quiet of whose every thought is worth
A province!

Lady B. But when dice have consum'd all,
Your patience will not pawn for as much more.

Born. Hang pawning! Sell outright, and the fear 's over.

Lady B. Say you so? I 'll have another coach to-morrow
If there be rich above ground.

Born. I forgot
To bid the fellow ask my jeweller
Whether the chain of diamonds be made up;
I will present it to my Lady Bellamour,
Fair Celestina.

Lady B. This gown I have worn
Six days already; it looks dull, I 'll give it
My waiting-woman, and have one of cloth
Of gold embroidered; shoes and pantables[4340]
Will show well of the same.

Born. I have invited
A covey of ladies, and as many gentlemen
To-morrow, to the Italian ordinary;
I shall have rarities and regalias[4341]
To pay for, madam; music, wanton songs,
And tunes of silken petticoats to dance to.

Lady B. And to-morrow have I invited half the court
To dine here. What misfortune 't is your company
And ours should be divided! After dinner
I entertain 'em with a play.

Born. By that time
Your play inclines to the epilogue, shall we
Quit our Italian host; and whirl in coaches
To the Dutch magazine of sauce, the Steelyard,
Where deal,[4342] and backrag,[4343] and what strange wine else
They dare but give a name to in the reckoning,
Shall flow into our room, and drown Westphalias,[4344]
Tongues, and anchovies, like some little town
Endangered by a sluice, through whose fierce ebb
We wade, and wash ourselves into a boat,
And bid our coachmen drive their leather tenements
By land, while we sail home, with a fresh tide,
To some new rendezvous.

Lady B. If you have not
'Pointed the place, pray bring your ladies hither;
I mean to have a ball to-morrow night,
And a rich banquet for 'em, where we 'll dance
Till morning rise, and blush to interrupt us.

Born. Have you no ladies i' th' next room, to advance[4345]
A present mirth? What a dull house you govern!
Farewell! a wife 's no company. - Aretina,
I 've summ'd up my estate, and find we may have
A month good yet.

Lady B. What mean you?

Born. And I'd rather
Be lord one month of pleasures, to the height
And rapture of our senses, than be years
Consuming what we have in foolish temperance,
Live in the dark, and no fame wait upon us!
I will live so, posterity shall stand
At gaze when I am mentioned.

Lady B. A month good!
And what shall be done then?

Born. I 'll over sea,
And trail a pike. With watching, marching, lying
In trenches, with enduring cold and hunger,
And taking here and there a musket-shot,
I can earn every week four shillings, madam;
And if the bullets favour me to snatch
Any superfluous limb, when I return,
With good friends, I despair not to be enroll'd
Poor knight of Windsor.[4346] For your course, madam,
No doubt you may do well; your friends are great;
Or if your poverty and their pride cannot
Agree, you need not trouble much invention
To find a trade to live by; there are customers.
Farewell, be frolic, madam! If I live,
I will feast all my senses, and not fall
Less than a Phaeton from my throne of pleasure,
Though my estate flame like the world about me. Exit.

Lady B. 'T is very pretty! -
Enter DECOY.
Madam Decoy!

Dec. What! melancholy,
After so sweet a night's work? Have not I
Show'd myself mistress of my art?

Lady B. A lady.

Dec. That title makes the credit of the act
A story higher. Y' have not seen him yet?
I wonder what he 'll say.

Lady B. He 's here.

Enter KICKSHAW and FREDERICK.

Kick. Bear up,
My little myrmidon; does not Jack Littleworth
Follow?

Fred. Follow? He fell into the Thames
At landing.

Kick. The devil shall dive for him,
Ere I endanger my silk stockings for him.
Let the watermen alone, they have drags and engines.[4347]
When he has drunk his julep, I shall laugh
To see him come in pickled the next tide.

Fred. He'll never sink, he has such a cork brain.

Kick. Let him be hang'd or drown'd, all 's one to me;
Yet he deserves to die by water, cannot
Bear his wine credibly.

Fred. Is not this my aunt?

Kick. And another handsome lady; I must know her.
[Goes up to DECOY.]

Fred. My blood is rampant too, I must court somebody;
As good my aunt as any other body.

Lady B. Where have you been, cousin?

Fred. At the Bridge,
At the Bear's foot, where our first health began
To the fair Aretina, whose sweet company
Was wished by all. We could not get a lay,
A tumbler, a device, a bona roba,[4348]

For any money; drawers were grown dull:
We wanted our true firks,[4349] and our vagaries. -
When were you in drink, aunt?

Lady B. How?

Fred. Do not ladies
Play the good fellows too? There 's no true mirth
Without 'em. I have now such tickling fancies!
That doctor of the chair of wit has read
A precious lecture, how I should behave
Myself to ladies - as now, for example.
[Goes up to LADY BORNWELL.]

Lady B. Would you practise upon me?

Fred. I first salute you,
You have a soft hand, madam; are you so
All over?

Lady B. Nephew!

Fred. Nay, you should but smile.
And then again I kiss you; and thus draw
Off your white glove, and start, to see your hand
More excellently white. I grace my own
Lip with this touch, and turning gently thus,
Prepare you for my skill in palmistry,
Which, out of curiosity, no lady
But easily applies[4350] to. The first line
I look with most ambition to find out,
Is Venus' girdle, a fair semicircle,
Enclosing both the mount of Sol and Saturn;
If that appear, she 's for my turn; a lady
Whom nature has prepared for the career;
And, Cupid at my elbow, I put forward:
You have this very line, aunt.

Lady B. The boy 's frantic!

Fred. You have a couch or pallet; I can shut
The chamber door. Enrich a stranger, when
Your nephew 's coming into play!

Lady B. No more.

Fred. Are you so coy to your own flesh and blood?

Kick. Here, take your playfellow; I talk of sport,
And she would have me marry her.

Fred. Here 's Littleworth.
Enter LITTLEWORTH, wet.
Why, how now, tutor?

Little. I have been fishing.

Fred. And what ha' you caught?

Little. My belly full of water.

Kick. Ha, ha! Where 's thy rapier?

Little. My rapier is drown'd,
And I am little better. I was up by th' heels,
And out came a tun of water, beside wine.

Kick. 'T has made thee sober.

Little. Would you have me drunk
With water?

Lady B. I hope your fire is quench'd by this time.

Fred. It is not now, as when your worship "walk'd
By all the taverns, Jack, dry as a bone."

Kick. You had store of fish under water, Jack.

Little. It has made a poor John of me.

Fred. I do not think but if we cast an angle
Into his belly, we might find some pilchards.[4351]

Little. And boil'd, by this time. - Dear madam, a bed.

Kick. Carry but the water-spaniel to a grass-plot,
Where he may roll himself; let him but shake
His ears twice in the sun, and you may grind him
Into a posset.

Fred. Come, thou shalt to my bed,
Poor pickerel.

Dec. Alas, sweet gentleman!

Little. I have ill luck an I should smell by this time;
I am but new ta'en, I am sure. - Sweet gentlewoman!

Dec. Your servant.

Little. Pray do not pluck off my skin;
It is so wet, unless you have good eyes,
You 'll hardly know it from a shirt.

Dec. Fear nothing.
Exeunt [all but KICKSHAW and Lady BORNWELL.]

Lady B. [Aside.] He has sack enough, and I may find his humour.

Kick. And how is 't with your Ladyship? You look
Without a sunshine in your face.

Lady B. You are glorious
In mind and habit.

Kicks. Ends of gold and silver!

Lady B. Your other clothes were not so rich. Who was
Your tailor, sir?

Kick. They were made for me long since;
They have known but two bright days upon my back.
I had a humour, madam, to lay things by;
They will serve two days more: I think I ha' gold enough
To go to th' mercer. I 'll now allow myself
A suit a week, as this, with necessary
Dependances, beaver, silk stockings, garters,
And roses, in their due conformity;
Boots are forbid a clean leg, but to ride in.
My linen every morning comes in new,
The old goes to great bellies.

Lady B. You are charitable.

Kick. I may dine wi' ye sometime, or at the court,
To meet good company, not for the table.
My clerk o' th' kitchen 's here, a witty epicure,
A spirit, that, to please me with what 's rare,
Can fly a hundred mile a day to market,
And make me lord of fish and fowl. I shall
Forget there is a butcher; and to make
My footman nimble, he shall feed on nothing
But wings of wild fowl.

Lady B. These ways are costly.

Kick. Therefore I 'll have it so; I ha' sprung a mine.

Lady B. You make me wonder, sir, to see this change
Of fortune: your revenue was not late
So plentiful.

Kick. Hang dirty land, and lordships!
I wo' not change one lodging I ha' got,
For the Chamber of London.

Lady B. Strange, of such a sudden,
To rise to this estate! No fortunate hand
At dice could lift you up so, for 't is since
Last night: yesterday, you were no such monarch.

Kick. There be more games than dice.

Lady B. It cannot be
A mistress, though your person is worth love;
None possibly are rich enough to feed
As you have cast the method of your riots.
A princess, after all her jewels, must
Be forc'd to sell her provinces.

Kick. Now you talk
Of jewels, what do you think of this?

Lady B. A rich one.

Kick. You 'll honour me to wear 't; this other toy
I had from you; this chain I borrowed of you,
A friend had it in keeping. [Gives her the jewel and chain.] - If
your ladyship
Want any sum, you know your friend, and Alexander.

Lady B. Dare you trust my security?

Kick. There 's gold,
I shall have more to-morrow.

Lady B. You astonish me;
Who can supply these?

Kick. A dear friend I have.
She promis'd we should meet again i' th' morning.

Lady B. Not that I wish to know
More of your happiness than I have already
Heart to congratulate, - be pleas'd to lay
My wonder.

Kick. 'T is a secret -

Lady B. Which I 'll die
Ere I 'll betray.

Kick. You have always wish'd me well;
But you shall swear not to reveal the party.

Lady B. I 'll lose the benefit of my tongue.

Kick. Nor be
Afraid at what I say. What think you first
Of an old witch, a strange ill-favour'd hag,
That, for my company last night, has wrought
This cure upon my fortune? I do sweat
To think upon her name.

Lady B. How, sir! a witch?

Kick. I would not fright your ladyship too much
At first, but witches are akin to spirits.
The truth is - Nay, if you look pale already,
I ha' done.

Lady B. Sir, I beseech you.

Kick. If you have
But courage then to know the truth, I 'll tell you
In one word: my chief friend is - the devil!

Lady B. What devil? how I tremble!

Kick. Have a heart;
'T was a she-devil too, a most insatiate,
Abominable devil, with a tail
Thus long.

Lady B. Goodness defend me! Did you see her?

Kick. No, 't was i' th' dark; but she appear'd first to me
I' th' likeness of a beldam, and was brought,
I know not how, nor whither, by two goblins,

More hooded than a hawk.

Lady B. But would you venture
Upon a devil!

Kick. Ay, for means.

Lady B. [Aside.] How black
An impudence is this! - But are you sure
It was the devil you enjoy'd?

Kick. Say nothing;
I did the best to please her; but as sure
As you live, 't was a hell-cat.

Lady B. D' ye not quake?

Kick. I found myself in the very room[4352] i' th' morning,
Where two of her familiars had left me.

Enter Servant.

Serv. My lord is come to visit you.

Kick. No words,
As you respect my safety. I ha' told tales
Out of the devil's school; if it be known,
I lose a friend. 'T is now about the time
I promis'd her to meet again; at my
Return I 'll tell you wonders. Not a word. Exit.

Lady B. 'T is a false glass; sure I am more deform'd:
[Looks in her pocket mirror.]
What have I done? - My soul is miserable.

Enter LORD - - .

Lord. I sent you a letter, madam.

Lady B. You exprest
Your noble care of me, my lord.

Re-enter SIR THOMAS BORNWELL with CELESTINA.

Born. Your lordship
Does me an honour.

Lord. Madam, I am glad

To see you here; I meant to have kist your hand,
Ere my return to court.

Cel. Sir Thomas has
Prevail'd to bring me, to his trouble, hither.

Lord. You do him grace.

Born. Why, what 's the matter, madam?
Your eyes are tuning Lachrimae.[4353]

Lady B. As you
Do hope for Heaven, withdraw, and give me but
The patience of ten minutes.

Born. Wonderful!
I will not hear you above that proportion.
She talks of Heaven: - Come, where must we to counsel?

Lady B. You shall conclude me when you please. [Exit.]

Born. I follow.

Lord. [Aside.] What alteration is this? I, that so late
Stood the temptation of her eye and voice,
Boasted a heart 'bove all licentious flame,
At second view turn renegade, and think
I was too superstitious, and full
Of phlegm, not to reward her amorous courtship
With manly freedom.

Cel. I obey you, sir.

Born. I 'll wait upon your lordship presently. [Exit.]

Lord. She could not want a cunning to seem honest
When I neglected her. I am resolv'd. -
You still look pleasant, madam.

Cel. I have cause,
My lord, the rather for your presence, which
Hath power to charm all trouble in my thoughts.

Lord. I must translate that compliment, and owe
All that is cheerful in myself to these
All-quick'ning smiles; and rather than such bright
Eyes should repent their influence upon me,
I would release the aspects, and quit the bounty

Of all the other stars. Did you not think me
A strange and melancholy gentleman,
To use you so unkindly?

Cel. Me, my lord?

Lord. I hope you made no loud complaint; I would not
Be tried by a jury of ladies.

Cel. For what, my lord?

Lord. I did not meet that noble entertainment
You were late pleas'd to show me.

Cel. I observ'd
No such defect in your lordship, but a brave
And noble fortitude.

Lord. A noble folly;
I bring repentance for 't. I know you have,
Madam, a gentle faith, and wo' not ruin
What you have built to honour you.

Cel. What 's that?

Lord. If you can love, I 'll tell your ladyship.

Cel. I have a stubborn soul else.

Lord. You are all
Compos'd of harmony.

Cel. What love d' ye mean?

Lord. That which doth perfect both. Madam, you have heard
I can be constant, and if you consent
To grace it so, there is a spacious dwelling
Prepar'd within my heart for such a mistress.

Cel. Your mistress, my good lord?

Lord. Why, my good lady,
Your sex doth hold it no dishonour
To become mistress to a noble servant
In the now court Platonic way. Consider
Who 't is that pleads to you; my birth and present
Value can be no stain to your embrace;
But these are shadows when my love appears,

Which shall, in his first miracle, return
Me in my bloom of youth, and thee a virgin;
When I, within some new Elysium,
Of purpose made and meant for us, shall be
In every thing Adonis, but in his
Contempt of love; and court thee from a Daphne
Hid in the cold rind of a bashful tree,
With such warm language and delight, till thou
Leap from that bay[4354] into the Queen of Love,
And pay my conquest with composing garlands
Of thy own myrtle for me.

Cel. What 's all this?

Lord. Consent to be my mistress, Celestina,
And we will have it spring-time all the year;
Upon whose invitations, when we walk,
The winds shall play soft descant to our feet,
And breathe rich odours to re-pure the air:
Green bowers on every side shall tempt our stay,
And violets stoop to have us tread upon 'em.
The red rose shall grow pale, being near thy cheek,
And the white blush, o'ercome with such a forehead.
Here laid, and measuring with ourselves some bank,
A thousand birds shall from the woods repair,
And place themselves so cunningly behind
The leaves of every tree, that while they pay
Us tribute of their songs, them sha't imagine
The very trees bear music, and sweet voices
Do grow in every arbour. Here can we
Embrace and kiss, tell tales, and kiss again,
And none but Heaven our rival.

Cel. When we are
Weary of these, what if we shift our paradise,
And through a grove of tall and even pine,
Descend into a valley, that shall shame
All the delights of Tempe; upon whose
Green plush the Graces shall be call'd to dance
To please us, and maintain their fairy revels,
To the harmonious murmurs of a stream
That gently falls upon a rock of pearl.
Here doth the nymph, forsaken Echo, dwell,
To whom we 'll tell the story of our love,
Till at our surfeit and her want of joy,
We break her heart with envy. Not far off,
A grove shall call us to a wanton river,
To see a dying swan give up the ghost,

The fishes shooting up their tears in bubbles,
That they must lose the genius of their waves -
And such love linsey woolsey, to no purpose.

Lord. You chide me handsomely; pray tell me how
You like this language.

Cel. Good my lord, forbear.

Lord. You need not fly out of this circle, madam; -
These widows are so full of circumstance! -
I 'll undertake, in this time I ha' courted
Your ladyship for the toy, to ha' broken ten,
Nay, twenty colts, virgins I mean, and taught 'em
The amble, or what pace I most affected.

Cel. You 're not, my lord, again, the lord I thought you;
And I must tell you now, you do forget
Yourself and me.

Lord. You 'll not be angry, madam?

Cel. Nor rude, (though gay men have a privilege,)
It shall appear: - there is a man, my lord,
Within my acquaintance, rich in worldly fortunes,
But cannot boast any descent of blood,
Would buy a coat of arms.

Lord. He may, and legs
Booted and spurr'd, to ride into the country.

Cel. But these will want antiquity, my lord,
The seal of honour. What 's a coat cut out
But yesterday, to make a man a gentleman?
Your family, as old as the first virtue
That merited an escutcheon, doth owe[4355]
A glorious coat of arms; if you will sell now
All that your name doth challenge in that ensign,
I 'll help you to a chapman that shall pay,
And pour down wealth enough for 't.

Lord. Sell my arms!
I cannot, madam.

Cel. Give but your consent,
You know not how the state may be inclin'd
To dispensation; we may prevail
Upon the Herald's office afterward.

Lord. I 'll sooner give these arms to th' hangman's axe,
My head, my heart, to twenty executions,
Than sell one atom from my name.

Cel. Change that,
And answer him would buy my honour from me;
Honour, that is not worn upon a flag
Or pennon, that, without the owner's dangers,
An enemy may ravish, and bear from me;
But that which grows and withers with my soul,
Beside the body's stain: think, think, my lord,
To what you would unworthily betray me,
If you would not, for price of gold, or pleasure,
(If that be more your idol,) lose the glory
And painted honour of your house. - I ha' done.

Lord. Enough to rectify a satyr's blood.
Obscure my blushes here.

Enter SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE and HAIRCUT.

Hair. Or this, or fight with me;
It shall be no exception that I wait
Upon my lord; I am a gentleman,
You may be less and be a knight: the office
I do my lord is honest, sir. How many
Such you have been guilty of, Heaven knows.

Scent. 'T is no fear of your sword, but that I would not
Break the good laws establish'd against duels.

Hair. Off with your periwig, and stand bare.
[SIR WILLIAM SCENTLOVE takes off his periwig.]

Lord. From this
Minute I 'll be a servant to thy goodness;
A mistress in the wanton sense is common,
I 'll honour you with chaste thoughts, and call you so.

Cel. I 'll study to be worth your fair opinion.

Lord. Scentlove, your head was us'd to a covering,
Beside a hat; when went the hair away?

Scent. I laid a wager, my lord, with Haircut,
Who thinks I shall catch cold, that I 'll stand bare
This half hour.

Hair. Pardon my ambition,
Madam, I told you truth; I am a gentleman,
And cannot fear that name is drown'd in my
Relation to my lord.

Cel. I dare not think so.

Hair. From henceforth call my service duty, madam.
That pig's head, that betray'd me to your mirth,
Is doing penance for 't.

Scent. Why may not I,
My lord, begin a fashion of no hair?

Cel. Do you sweat, Sir William?

Scent. Not with store of nightcaps.

Re-enter SIR THOMAS and LADY BORNWELL.

Lady B. Heaven has dissolv'd the clouds that hung upon
My eyes, and if you can with mercy meet
A penitent, I throw my own will off,
And now in all things obey yours. My nephew
Send back again to th' college, and myself
To what place you 'll confine me.

Born. Dearer now
Than ever to my bosom, thou sha't please
Me best to live at thy own choice. I did
But fright thee with a noise of my expenses;
The sums are safe, and we have wealth enough,
If yet we use it nobly. My lord - madam,
Pray honour us to-night.

Lady B. I beg your presence,
And pardon.

Born. I know not how my Aretina
May be dispos'd to-morrow for the country.

Cel. You must not go before you have done
Me honour to accept an entertainment
Where I have power; on those terms I 'm your guest.

Born. You grace us, madam.

Lady B. [Aside.] Already
I feel a cure upon my soul, and promise
My after life to virtue. Pardon, Heaven,
My shame, yet hid from the world's eye.

Re-enter DECOY.

Dec. Sweet madam!

Lady B. Not for the world be seen here! We are lost.
I 'll visit you at home. - [Aside.] But not to practise
What she expects: my counsel may recover her. [Exit DECOY.]

Re-enter KICKSHAW.

Kick. Where 's madam? - Pray lend me a little money,
My spirit has deceiv'd me; Proserpine
Has broke her word.

Lady B. Do you expect to find
The devil true to you?

Kick. Not too loud.

Lady B. I 'll voice it
Louder, to all the world, your horrid sin,
Unless you promise me religiously,
To purge your foul blood by repentance, sir.

Kick. Then I 'm undone.

Lady B. Not while I have power
To encourage you to virtue. I 'll endeavour
To find you out some nobler way at court,
To thrive in.

Kick. Do 't and I 'll forsake the devil,
And bring my flesh to obedience. You shall steer me. -
My lord, your servant.

Lord. You are brave again.

Kick. Madam, your pardon.

Born. Your offence requires
Humility.

Kick. Low as my heart. - Sir Thomas,

I 'll sup with you, a part of satisfaction.

Born. Our pleasures cool. Music! and when our ladies
Are tir'd with active motion, to give
Them rest, in some new rapture to advance
Full mirth, our souls shall leap into a dance. Exeunt.

NOTES ON THIS TEXT

[4233] A room in Sir Thomas Bornwell's house.

[4234] In the Q. Lady Bornwell is called Aretina throughout in stage directions and speech-tags.

[4235] A common country-dance tune. Cf. p. 487.

[4236] Characters in the morris-dance.

[4237] Expense.

[4238] Unjust.

[4239] Desire.

[4240] Headdresses.

[4241] Obstruct.

[4242] A religious sect often accused of licentiousness.

[4243] "The Ball," a comedy by Shirley and Chapman, 1632.

[4244] Moderate.

[4245] Corset.

[4246] Candied orange-peel.

[4247] Indulged.

[4248] Appeal, demand(?).

[4249] What sort of.

[4250] Like.

[4251] Gutter.

[4252] A room in Celestina's house.

[4253] Will it? Gifford reads with 't.

[4254] Courtesans.

[4255] A suburban resort for cakes and cream.

[4256] Chair-men.

[4257] Splendor.

[4258] Lower.

[4259] Jocular.

[4260] A room in Sir Thomas Bornwell's house.

[4261] Title, ornament.

[4262] Vain-glorious.

[4263] I. e. Bad luck.

[4264] Hair.

[4265] Pleased.

[4266] Usually, a mould for shaping a hat; here, head.

[4267] A room in Celestina's house.

[4268] Expensive.

[4269] Flemish.

[4270] Foolishly eager.

[4271] Devices, schemings.

[4272] Ordinary kiss of salutation.

[4273] Lover.

[4274] Lose the scent.

[4275] Cf. 1 Henry IV, II. ii. 2, "I have hid Falstaff's horse, and he frets like gumm'd velvet." (Gifford.)

[4276] Chastities.

[4277] Lord - - 's house.

[4278] Undressed.

[4279] Wait.

[4280] Obligation.

[4281] Accessible.

[4282] The punishment of bawds was to be whipt and carted.

[4283] Chaste.

[4284] Pay observance, worship.

[4285] Brought back.

[4286] A room in Sir Thomas Bornwell's house.

[4287] Absolute, unmixed.

[4288] Accuse.

[4289] Comforting.

[4290] Made of silk and gold thread.

[4291] Q. reads least.

[4292] A small vessel.

[4293] Cannon charged with grape-shot.

[4294] Q. continues of the bears to Littleworth.

[4295] I. e. Were drunk.

[4296] A cheap substitute for tapestry.

[4297] A quick, lively dance.

[4298] Chaste.

[4299] Characterizing.

[4300] The place of execution.

[4301] A contemptuous term, sometimes associated with pilchard, a small fish like a herring.

[4302] Devices.

[4303] Guilty consciousness.

[4304] A dance like a cotillion.

[4305] Jaundice(?)

[4306] Smoke.

[4307] A game at cards.

[4308] A room in Decoy's house.

[4309] Wrinkled, shrivelled.

[4310] A room in Sir Thomas Bornwell's house.

[4311] Span. Cuerpo, stripped of the upper garment.

[4312] Lombard Street: pawn-shops were common in Long Lane.

[4313] Been on the look-out.

[4314] Go-between.

[4315] A kind of milk-pudding.

[4316] Make arrangements.

[4317] Q. reads holds.

[4318] Bravo.

[4319] Gay women, prostitutes.

[4320] Foresight.

[4321] All.

[4322] Precedence.

[4323] Resident.

[4324] Lecture.

[4325] Waiter.

[4326] Pour out.

[4327] City militia.

[4328] Brought in comparison.

[4329] Perhaps, Oh.

[4330] Q. reads when.

[4331] A room in Celestina's house.

[4332] Q. yeares.

[4333] Q. knowne.

[4334] Q. were.

[4335] Charles I and Henrietta Maria.

[4336] A room in Sir Thomas Bornwell's house.

[4337] Thrower of the dice.

[4338] Gulls, simpletons.

[4339] Staked their coins(?).

[4340] Slippers.

[4341] Choice viands.

[4342] "Some unidentified kind of wine." (N. E. D.)

[4343] Baccarach, a famous Rhine wine.

[4344] Hams.

[4345] Rouse.

[4346] One of a small order of military knights with pensions and apartments in Windsor Castle.

[4347] Contrivances.

[4348] All four terms are euphemisms for courtesan.

[4349] A vague piece of contemporary slang, the meaning of which has usually to be derived from the context.

[4350] Yields.

[4351] A small fish, like a herring.

[4352] Gifford conj. Q. myself the very same.

[4353] A punning allusion to Dowland's Lacrimae or Seven Tears, etc., a popular musical work of the time for stringed instruments.

[4354] Daphne was transformed into a bay-tree.

[4355] Own.

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